



REFINEMENT CALL
Delhi SIR notices seem mechanically issued: SC
NEWS » PAGE 5



NATIONAL FILM AWARDS
President highlights impact of celebrities
NEWS » PAGE 6



NOTIFICATION NEXT WEEK
Elections to 12 Rajya Sabha seats on Oct. 16
NEWS » PAGE 6



FREEZING DEMOCRACY
An attack on the electorate
Election Commission is functioning as a tool of the BJP in West Bengal
EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



GOLDEN DAY
Harmanpreet & Co. on top of the podium
SPORT » PAGE 16

INSIDE



‘Squatting’ on mining assets a concern: official

Miners holding on to their acquired blocks without commencing timely operations — or ‘squatting’ — is an issue that the industry must look to address, Union Mines Secretary Keshav Chandra said at a meeting of the Federation of the Indian Mineral Industries on Tuesday. » **PAGE 12**

Civilians killed in Saudi strikes on Yemen: Houthis

Yemen’s Houthis on Tuesday accused Saudi Arabia of carrying out a spate of deadly strikes that killed civilians and prison inmates, as Riyadh seeks to repel an offensive that has seen the rebel group seize strategic territory. » **PAGE 14**

Main accused in harassment case in Bihar arrested

The prime accused in the molestation and harassment of a Class 10 girl was shot in the leg during a police encounter on Tuesday in Bihar’s Jamui district. » **PAGE 4**

Keralam to probe charges against Vijayan, daughter

The Keralam government on Tuesday ordered an inquiry into the CMRL-Exalogic payoff controversy centring former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and his daughter. » **PAGE 3**

Cannot penalise refusal to sing National Song: SC

Court seeks response on appeal challenging Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act

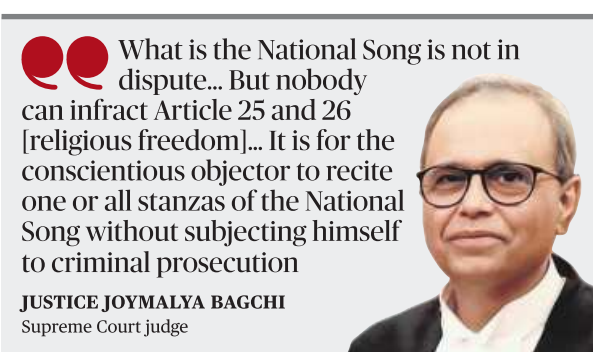
Central govt. cannot violate religious freedoms or penalise conscientious objectors, top court says

Petitioner said stanzas three to six of *Vande Mataram* were ‘devotional and non-secular’

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday observed that while a democratically elected government may give shape to the scope and length of the National Song, it cannot violate individual and collective religious freedoms or subject conscientious objectors, who refuse to sing one or all the stanzas of the *Vande Mataram*, to penal consequences. “What is the National Song is not in dispute... It is for the democratically-elected state to decide and give aspiration as to what the National Song is, whether it should be two stanzas or four stanzas. But nobody can infract Article 25 and 26 [religious freedom] or subject a conscientious objector to penal consequences... It is for the conscientious objector to recite one or all stanzas

of the National Song without subjecting himself to criminal prosecution,” Justice Joymalya Bagchi, part of a three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, observed. He said the 1986 Supreme Court precedent in the *Bijoe Emmanuel versus State of Kerala* upholding the right to religious freedom, constitutional tolerance, and silent objection still holds true. The court sought a response from the Union government on a petition filed by renowned Carnatic vocalist T.M. Krishna challenging the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act, 2026, read with the administrative directions issued by the Union Home Ministry in January and a subsequent circular in July. Mr. Krishna, represented by senior advocate S. Muralidhar and advocate Prasanna S., said the



amended law and executive orders compel the playing and mass singing of the entire six stanzas of *Vande Mataram* ahead of the National Anthem at public functions. Non-compliance would risk three years’ imprisonment or fine or both. Stanzas three to six of *Vande Mataram* were “expressly devotional, deity-invoking, and non-secular” and the scheme violated fundamental rights guaranteed under the Constitution and offended the basic fea-

ture of secularism, the petitioner said. The petition said the amended Section 3 of the Act not only regulates national protocol and prescribes a uniform code of conduct for public functions, but also “compels a ceremony of assent to a symbol whose last four stanzas are expressly devotional, deity-invoking and non-secular”. “By mandating the rendition of all six stanzas under penal sanction, the state transforms what is

unquestionably a contested historical symbol into a compelled orthodoxy. The measure is formally neutral but, manifestly, substantively coded. It sends a signal of majoritarian religious alignment and inflicts expressive subordination on believing Muslims and other conscientious objectors,” the petition said.

Define ‘National Song’ “The 2026 Act does not even define what a ‘National Song’ is,” Dr. Muralidhar submitted in the hearing. Chief Justice Kant said anybody who took pains to read history would know the National Song. Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, who was present in the court room, intervened to point out that *Vande Mataram* was the National Song since pre-Independence. Justice Bagchi said customs and usages could also be called upon to reach the

same conclusion too. Justice Bagchi, in the initial moments of the hearing, said religious flavour or an icon or homage to a particular God may not perhaps impact secularism in a constitutional democracy. “If so, nothing can be a stronger example of positive secularism than the American Constitution, yet the American National Anthem uses the word ‘God’,” the Judge reasoned. Noting that the court is often loath to articulate national aspirations or second-guess nationalism, Justice Bagchi said the Bench would definitely examine if the 2026 amendment and the government circulars choke the rights of conscientious objectors. Mr. Mehta interjected to remark, “let us not bag the National Song in sensationalism”. “We are not here to create sensations. We are here only to ensure that

the law of the land declared under the Bijoe Emmanuel judgment governs the 2026 amendment of the Act,” Justice Bagchi said. Dr. Muralidhar criticised the law-making process, saying a definition of the ‘National Song’ required broader debate and consensus. He emphasised that it cannot be thrust upon citizens under threat of penal action. He further pointed out that the Home Ministry’s office memorandum was never gazetted and cited no supporting provision of law. The Solicitor General objected that “law-making process is done as per the Constitution, law-making cannot be as per Naxalites’ idea”. Mr. Mehta’s comment was strongly objected to by Dr. Muralidhar, saying it was offensive and did not behove the office of a law officer of the government.

Making a mark



Conservationist Purnima Devi Barman, right, who was named the *businessline* Changemaker of the Year, with Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and Nirmala Lakshman, Director and Publisher, The Hindu Group, in New Delhi on Tuesday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR (REPORT: PAGE 5)

Three infants killed in fire at hospital

Siddharth Kumar Singh
HYDERABAD

Three infants died after a fire broke out at the Special Newborn Care Unit ward of Rajiv Gandhi Institute of Medical Sciences in Adilabad district of Telangana late on Monday. According to Adilabad District Medical and Health Officer Sadhana, the fire was likely caused after an air-conditioner in the reception area of the new born care unit burst into flames.

FULL REPORT ON
» **PAGE 3**

Trade deal unlikely till U.S. probes India’s competitors also over excess capacity

Sriram Lakshman
WASHINGTON DC

India and the U.S. are unlikely to sign a trade deal until the United States launches a series of fresh ‘Section 301 investigations’, concludes them, and places tariffs on India’s competitors such as Pakistan, Sri Lanka, and the Philippines, a person familiar with the process has said.

It was a “strategic mistake”, according to the person, that Pakistan was not included in the list of countries investigated in the ‘excess capacity’ 301 investigations opened in March 2026. An announcement of fresh 301 investigations against some of India’s competitor countries is likely in the near future, *The Hindu* has learned, although the timelines and the subject matters for these 301s have not yet been decided. For this reason, it is highly unlikely that a trade deal will be concluded around Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal’s upcoming visit to the North American country for the G-20 trade ministerial that starts on September 30. These developments appear to be consistent with Commerce Secretary Rakesh Agrawal’s remarks at the Global Fintech Fest 2026 earlier this month. Mr. Agrawal had said that India operates largely on an MFN (Most Favoured Nation) tariff basis, while the U.S. operates on an executive tariff basis, and that a trade agreement would require an architecture with differentials and

Uneven markets

The United States government uses ‘Section 301’ as an alternative to the ‘reciprocal tariffs’

- India, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka were subject to probes for ‘forced labour’, but only India is on the probe list for ‘excess capacity’
- India is likely to face 8% tariff in the ‘excess capacity’ investigation to bring the overall tariff rate it faces up to 18%



preferential market access structure for India.

The ‘301s’ are part of how the U.S. government is working around the February 2026 U.S. Supreme Court ruling that President Donald Trump’s ‘reciprocal’ tariffs were an unlawful application of the International Emergency Economic Powers Act. Prior to this ruling, India and the U.S. had arrived at an Interim Agreement on trade that was announced via an India-U.S. joint statement issued on February 6. The general tariff rate for Indian goods entering the U.S. under the interim deal was going to be 18%, giving India an advantage over its main competitors. These include not just Pakistan (19%), which is the most politically sensitive country in New Delhi’s calculus, but also Vietnam (20%), Sri Lanka (20%), Bangladesh (19%) and the Philippines (19%). Following the scrapping of these tariffs, they trade with the U.S. on an MFN basis.

Central challenge

A central challenge to concluding the India-U.S. deal is that Pakistan, Sri Lanka and the Philippines were subject to 301 probes for

forced labour, but are not on the 301 probe list for excess capacity, which India was subject to. Both probes were launched in March 2026. Pakistan, for instance, is tariffed at 10% as a result of the forced labour 301 investigation. So, at the moment, there are no similar legal instruments through which tariff rates on these countries could be raised further to their previous levels, while India is likely to be tariffed at 8% in the excess capacity investigation, bringing the overall tariff rate it faces back up to 18%. To complicate matters, last Friday, Mr. Trump signed the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act into law, enabling the U.S. government to impose up to 100% tariffs on the top five importers of Russian oil. This includes India and China. New Delhi is the second-biggest market for Russian crude oil. There is reporting to suggest that the bill, which was originally scheduled for consideration after the midterm elections, was rushed through in time for the September 24 meeting between Chinese President Xi Jinping and Mr. Trump in Washington, DC.

Three men posing as police rape girl in Delhi

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A 17-year-old girl was gang-raped by three men who posed as police personnel at Astha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Mandir in southeast Delhi on Monday night. The girl’s 17-year-old male friend was also assaulted. The accused were identified as Asif, 31, a resident of Tughlakabad; Hemanth, 31, who claims to be an advocate practising at the Saket court; and his brother Mukesh, 24, a B.Sc. student from Palwal in Haryana. The brothers are residents of Sriniwasपुरी. All three accused were arrested on Tuesday. Asif was shot in the leg during a police operation on Tuesday morning. It was the girl’s birthday on Monday. A resident of Faridabad, she had come to southeast Delhi to meet her 17-year-old friend. The two visited Kalkaji Mandir before entering Astha Kunj Park.



Probe on: Special staff of the Delhi Police conduct an investigation at the encounter site after one of the accused was arrested. ANI

“The three accused approached them, claimed to be policemen, and used police and legal terminology to intimidate the two, telling them that they were minors, had done something wrong, and could face a case. The trio then separated the girl by taking her to a secluded spot while restraining the boy, and sexually assaulted the girl one after another,” Joint Commissioner of Police (Southern Range) Vijay Kumar told *The Hindu*. The police said Asif had

allegedly threatened the girl with a firearm and a knife before sexually assaulting her. The girl made a distress call at 8.45 p.m., after which Amar Colony police personnel reached the Astha Kunj Park. The girl was medically examined at AIIMS, while the Crime Team and Forensic Science Laboratory personnel examined the scene and collected evidence, police said. A case was registered under Sections 70(2), 61(2),

115(2), and 351(3) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and Sections 6 and 17 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. The police will seek custody of the accused for more questioning. This is the latest in a slew of recent sexual assaults against minor girls in Delhi. On September 10, a 16-year-old girl was allegedly gang-raped and killed in Swaroop Nagar. Four people, including three juveniles, were apprehended. On September 16, a minor girl was allegedly sexually assaulted inside a shop in Sadar Bazar. On September 21, a six-year-old girl was allegedly sexually assaulted in Kishan Ganj. The Delhi Commission for Women has taken *suo motu* cognisance of the latest case, seeking a detailed report from the police on the incident and action taken so far. Delhi Lieutenant-Governor T.S. Sandhu stressed

that women’s safety was “non-negotiable”. He directed the city police to establish a dedicated women-centric ‘Pink Force’, with trained women personnel deployed near schools, colleges and Metro stations. **‘Deteriorating situation’** The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Congress on Tuesday hit out at the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led government in Delhi over the deteriorating law and order situation in the capital. AAP Delhi chief Saurabh Bharadwaj said the police functioned as a political tool instead of acting against criminals operating openly across the city. The Congress said that the rape of four minors in a span of 10 days in the capital showed the worsening law and order, rising crimes against women and the failure of the government in protecting women.

INBRIEF



‘I express regret’: M.P. Minister on row over woman remark

Madhya Pradesh Cabinet Minister and senior BJP leader Kailash Vijayvargiya on Tuesday expressed regret over his recent controversial remarks about the body of a woman party councillor from Indore. At an event on Sunday in the city, Mr. Vijayvargiya said the councillor's width had increased a little, which drew sharp criticism from the Congress. “She is like my daughter. This is why neither do I have anything bad in my mind about her nor does she. I express my regrets in this matter,” the Minister said.

Bombay HC bans bursting of firecrackers on public roads

Festivals can be celebrated without causing noise and air pollution, the Bombay High Court said on Tuesday while ordering a complete ban on the bursting of firecrackers on public roads. Passing the order amid the Ganesh festival, a bench of Justices Girish Kulkarni and Neela Gokhale also said that the use of loudspeakers, DJs and laser beams during religious processions was “completely unwarranted”. “As a responsible society, we should put an end to all this,” the HC said. The court had on Monday taken suo motu (on its own) cognizance of the issue of severe noise and air pollution caused during processions.

Congress candidate can be allowed to fight Nandigram byelection if he gets bail: HC

Candidate's lawyer says arrest on Sept. 18 came after he received support from Mamata Banerjee; matter listed for further consideration on October 12; ISF leader files plea over ‘almirah’ symbol

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

The Calcutta High Court on Tuesday told the West Bengal government that Congress's Nandigram bypoll candidate Milan Pradhan be allowed to contest the election properly, provided he gets bail in the five criminal cases in which he has been arrested.

Mr. Pradhan was on Saturday sent to judicial custody by the Haldia Sub-Divisional Court until October 3 in connection with four pending non-bailable arrest warrants linked to cases in Nandigram dating back to 2007. On Monday, the Contai court sent the Congress candidate to 14 days' judicial custody, until October 5, in a case under the Arms Act registered nearly two decades ago. The bypoll in Nandigram is slated for October 6. The campaign ends on October 4, and the counting of votes is scheduled for October 9.



Congress leaders staging a protest rally against the arrest of party candidate Milan Pradhan in Kolkata on September 19.

Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya verbally told Additional Advocate General Rajdeep Majumdar, representing the State, that Mr. Pradhan be allowed to contest the election properly, provided he gets bail.

Mr. Pradhan's counsel, Ayan Bhattacharjee, informed the court that he was arrested on September 18 in connection with cases lodged during the anti-land acquisition movement in Nandigram in 2007, only after he received support from the Mamata Banerjee-led All India Trinamool Congress for the bypoll.

Mr. Majumdar informed Justice Bhattacharyya that 11 criminal cases had been registered against Mr. Pradhan, but he was not wanted in the six cases mentioned by his lawyer, in which he had sought protection from coercive police action. Mr. Majumdar also said five of these six cases had been withdrawn by the previous government and in another case registered at Nandigram police station, Mr. Pradhan was not an accused.

The court directed that the matter be listed before him for further consideration on October 12.

Meanwhile, Indian Secular Front leader and MLA Naushad Siddiqui on Tuesday moved a petition before the High Court challenging the Election Commission of India's decision to replace the ‘envelope’ symbol, with which the party fought the April Assembly election, with the ‘almirah’ symbol. The ISF has put up a candidate for the Nandigram bypoll. The petition is likely to be heard later this week.

Extension sought

The 20 Lok Sabha MPs who quit the Trinamool Congress and aligned themselves with the NCPI have sought another four weeks to respond to notices issued by Speaker Om Birla on petitions seeking their disqualification under the anti-defection law. The deadline granted to them expired on Tuesday. NCPI parliamentary chairperson Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar said the MPs were yet to collate documents required for the response.

Nagaon LS bypoll: BJP, Cong. workers clash for second straight day

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Congress workers clashed for the second successive day during campaigning for the October 6 by-election to the Nagaon parliamentary constituency in Assam.

According to reports, ruling party workers blocked the vehicle of Congress MLA Asif Nazar at Garoimari in Morigaon district on Tuesday and a scuffle between workers of the two parties ensued.

District officials said the situation was brought under control after the police escorted Mr. Nazar's vehicle away from the spot.

On Monday, BJP workers had allegedly attacked the vehicles of Congress leaders who were travelling to Samaguri in adjoining Nagaon district for an election meeting.

Among the leaders were State Congress president Gaurav Gogoi and former Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel.

Police complaint

In a complaint to the local police, the Congress claimed that BJP supporters pelted stones at and

Assam CM says the Samaguri clash was between rival factions within the Congress

damaged the vehicle in which its candidate, Sibamoni Bora, was travelling. All India Congress Committee secretary Manoj Chauhan was injured in the attack, the party said.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, however, said the Samaguri clash was between rival factions within the Congress.

He advised the Congress leadership to keep its house in order and not let internal differences spill onto the streets.

The Nagaon Lok Sabha seat fell vacant after Pradyut Bordoloi quit the Congress and joined the BJP. He contested and won the Dispur Assembly seat on a BJP ticket in April 2026.

Although 15 candidates are vying for the Nagaon seat, the contest is expected to be among Ms. Bora, the BJP's Devasish Baruah, a former bureaucrat, and All India United Democratic Front chief Mohammed Badruddin Ajmal.

Can't be held responsible for individual acts of party cadre, wings: Stalin to HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin on Tuesday told the Madras High Court that he cannot be held responsible for each and every social media post published by different wings or functionaries of the party, just because he happens to be its leader.

He made the submission in a counter-affidavit in response to a ₹1-crore defamation suit filed against him and the DMK information technology (IT) wing by Tamil Nadu Minister for Public Works and Sports Development Aadhav Arjuna, who had taken exception to a post on X by the DMK IT wing.

“Though I am the head of the party and I exercise administrative control over the office-bearers of various wings of the party, I cannot be legally responsible for individual acts of party cadre, wings: Stalin to HC



M.K. Stalin was responding to a ₹1-crore defamation suit filed by Tamil Nadu Minister Aadhav Arjuna.

ble or liable for any individual acts of the members or wings of the party,” said the counter that was filed in response to the plea for interim relief.

The former Chief Minister also categorically denied having given any instruction or approval to the DMK IT wing to post the message, which stated that an individual named John Britto, who was booked by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) in a

drug-trafficking case, was the Minister's relative.

Hearing adjourned

Justice K. Govindarajan Thilakavadi adjourned the hearing on the application for interim relief to October 26, after advocate Richardson Wilson, representing the DMK president, told the court that the counter-affidavit had been served on the Minister's counsel, A.P. Suryaprakasam.

The judge was informed that the counter-affidavit of the DMK IT wing was also ready, and that it would be served on the plaintiff's counsel by the end of the day. The counsel requested the court to list the matter for arguments after the court's Dasara vacation.

Criminal cases

In his counter-affidavit, Mr. Stalin said the Minister had not denied the fact that he

had a relative by the name of John Britto, who was also facing an ED case. The court was told that the Minister's wife, mother-in-law, and father-in-law were also facing criminal cases registered by the ED.

Stating that the Minister himself was facing a probe by the Central Bureau of Investigation in connection with the Karur stampede, the DMK president added, “Therefore, the applicant's claim that linking him to an accused person has ruined his reputation is bizarre when there are pending criminal cases against his immediate family members and one criminal case pending against him.”

Mr. Stalin said Mr. Arjuna had described him as a “foolish Chief Minister”, which could not be considered mere political criticism, but a personal and derogatory attack.

Maharashtra Congress calls SIR deletions ‘alarming’, seeks two-month extension

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

A delegation of Maharashtra Congress met the State's Chief Electoral Officer S. Chockalingam on Tuesday and expressed apprehension that 30% of the electorate is likely to be disenfranchised. The leaders raised concerns and anomalies about the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and sought a two-month extension for submitting claims and objections.

In a six-page memorandum submitted to Mr. Chockalingam, the party highlighted widespread discrepancies in voter data, including numerous ‘unmapped’ and ‘anomalous’ entries, and the alleged unjustified removal of over two crore voters. The delegation expressed concern about the lack of transparency and adherence to



The Congress said of the 9,78,54,049 names on the electoral rolls before the SIR, 2,06,88,487, i.e. 21.14%, had been dropped.

due process, citing insufficient notice periods for voters and the challenging process for citizens to verify their electoral status.

Of the 9,78,54,049 names on the electoral rolls before the SIR, 2,06,88,487, i.e. 21.14%, had been dropped, the party said. Moreover, notices are going to be issued to 1,22,24,007 voters as ‘unmapped’ or ‘anomalous’, since their records have not matched with the 2002

electoral rolls. The Congress termed the deletion of more than 2.06 crore names between the 2024 Assembly election and August 31, 2026, as “unprecedented and alarming”.

“... the final voter list is likely to have a reduction of 20 to 25 per cent, which is substantial. It raises serious questions about the SIR process,” the six-page memorandum stated.

The party also claimed that 40 lakh new names

had been added to the Absent, Shifted, Duplicate, Dead and Others (ASDDO) list during the 2024 Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assembly elections.

The Congress also claimed that the SIR exercise had failed to effectively address the issue of duplicate voters. “Nearly 25,000 duplicate names have remained in six Assembly constituencies in Nagpur district - Kamthi, Hingna, Ramtek, Umred, Saoner and Katol,” the memorandum stated. The party demanded that the de-duplication software be used effectively to remove the duplication. It also sought a thorough probe in the matter. The Opposition party demanded a mandatory two-month extension for filing voter forms, claims and objections and sought at least three opportunities for hearings and submission of evidence.

Punjab's groundwater crisis widens social divide

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

Low utilisation of surface canal water, coupled with extensive cultivation of water-intensive crops, has triggered a severe groundwater crisis in Punjab, which in turn is exacerbating social and economic inequality across the State, according to a paper by Sandeep Kaur, Professor at the Central University of Punjab in Bathinda.

The paper, titled ‘Unequal Burden of Groundwater Depletion in Punjab’, shows that the State is experiencing one of the most critical groundwater crises in the country, with a staggering 76.47% of its groundwater blocks classified as over-exploited – the highest percentage among all States – and only 13.07% of blocks falling in the “safe” category.

The findings indicate that in most parts of Punjab, groundwater is being



A study shows the State is experiencing one of the most critical groundwater crises in the country.

extracted at rates far exceeding the natural replenishment capacity of aquifers.

Root cause

The root cause lies in the State's heavy reliance on groundwater for agriculture, particularly for cultivating water-intensive crops such as wheat and rice.

Prof. Kaur said only a small proportion of farmers in Punjab use surface canal water for irrigation.

Highlighting the critical role of financial capital in

enabling farmers to adopt efficient technologies and invest in agricultural inputs, Prof. Kaur noted in her paper that larger farmers with greater financial resources often expand their groundwater extraction systems by installing more borewells equipped with high-capacity motor pumps.

This allows them to access deeper groundwater levels, reduce cultivation costs and earn higher returns per unit cost than smaller farmers.

In contrast, small farmers have fewer pumping motors per unit area because most of their operational holdings consist of leased-in land.

“The implication is that large farmers, who contribute the most to environmental degradation and threaten water sustainability, benefit the most in terms of income accrued, while small and marginal farmers, who bear the cost of environmental degradation and water scarcity, contribute the least to environmental degradation,” Prof. Kaur said.

Experts voice concerns

“Punjab's blanket free agricultural electricity is economically crippling the vulnerable smallholders it was meant to protect. Capital-rich large farmers have proactively secured electricity connections for new and additional tubewells and have continuously, fearlessly deepened their

borewells to chase receding water tables. Running high-powered submersibles, they siphon most of Punjab's groundwater, fuelling an unregulated shadow economy,” S.K. Saluja, former Chief Engineer of the Ranjit Sagar and Shahpurkandi dam projects in Punjab, told *The Hindu*.

“Conversely, resource-poor small and marginal farmers lack the capital to deepen their tubewells and watch helplessly as shallow wells run dry. By maintaining this universal subsidy, the State actively funds a system that enriches wealthy landlords, drains the public exchequer, and accelerates the economic ruin of small farmers,” Mr. Saluja said.

Prof. Kaur said although the government had launched various schemes to tackle groundwater over-exploitation, they fell short of addressing the full scope of the problem.

BJP legislator strikes a different note on UCC in Mizoram

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

One of the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) two MLAs in Mizoram has called for a closer examination of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), in contrast to the State government's opposition to its implementation.

The 40-member Mizoram Assembly adopted a resolution in February 2023 opposing any move to implement the UCC in the State. Chief Minister Lalduhoma recently said the UCC was a threat to indigenous customary laws and minority rights.

BJP legislator K. Hrahmo, however, argued that implementing the UCC could provide greater legal protection to Mizo women married to non-tribal men. He represents the Palak As-

sembly constituency in Siahla district.

Speaking at a party programme at the BJP's office in Aizawl on Monday, Mr. Hrahmo said the implementation of the UCC in Mizoram should be seen in the context of marriages between Mizos and non-Mizos. Mr. Hrahmo said that opposition to laws introduced by the Centre often arises from political considerations or a lack of understanding of their provisions. He said tribal populations have been excluded from the ambit of the UCC and that such exemptions exist in States where it has been implemented.

“The Congress portrayed the UCC as dangerous for political gains, creating apprehension without analysing its provisions,” he said.

Odisha: two detained for ‘harassing’ tourist couple

Press Trust of India
BHUBANESWAR

The Odisha police on Tuesday detained two persons for allegedly harassing a young tourist couple on their way to the hill shrine of Kapilash in Dhenkanal district, an official said.

The police registered a case and detained the two accused after taking cognisance of a video widely shared on social media.

The official said the incident took place on an isolated stretch of a road leading to the Kapilash hills.

The video showed some people intercepting the bike-borne couple and assaulting the man, while the woman shouted for help. “An FIR has been registered at Gondia police station. An investigation is under way,” Dhenkanal SP Abhinav Sonkar said.



Drug trade to be uprooted from India by 2029 end: Shah

The Union Home Minister says enforcement agencies must break trafficking chains through financial investigations, tracing digital links, and targeting the profits generated by drug cartels

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday set a target of December 31, 2029 to “uproot” drug trade from the country.

“For the past five years, we have been taking one step after another in an effort to achieve the difficult goal of a drug-free India...the time has now come to deliver a decisive blow against narcotics, which have become the most serious threat to the country and the world, and to achieve victory through collective efforts. By 31 December 2029, we will collectively succeed in uprooting the drug trade from India,” Mr. Shah said.

The Minister said the country’s anti-narcotics strategy should shift from merely seizing drugs to dismantling the networks behind the trade. He directed agencies to launch a campaign to deport foreign nationals involved in drug trafficking and bar them



Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurates the third National Conference of Anti-Narcotics Task Force in New Delhi on Tuesday. ANI

from re-entering India. Fugitive traffickers operating from abroad should also be apprehended and brought before Indian courts, he said.

Addressing the third National Conference of Heads of Anti-Narcotics Task Force (ANTF) of States and Union Territories in Delhi, Mr. Shah said enforcement agencies must focus on breaking entire trafficking chains through financial investigations, tracing digital links, and targeting the profits generated by drug

cartels.

“Instead of maintaining a seizure-centric approach, we must move forward with the objective of dismantling entire networks,” he said, adding, cartels should be attacked at three levels: the entry point, the inter-State distribution system, and local sales networks within districts. To sharpen enforcement, districts will be classified into three categories: those where drugs are manufactured or enter the country, those that function as trans-

portation corridors, and those where drug consumption takes place.

Mr. Shah also called for greater use of the Prevention of Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act and stressed on the need for a comprehensive road map from investigation to conviction in coordination with public prosecutors.

The Minister said all loopholes along borders and drug production centres must be plugged and asked ANTFs to make the conversion of information into actionable intelligence an integral part of policing culture in their respective States.

Mr. Shah said the conference marked a transition “from meeting to mission, from reporting to results, from seizure to dismantling networks, and from case to conviction”.

The two-day conference, organised by the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB), is being attended by ANTF heads from 36 States and Union Territories.

Key accused in Bihar sexual harassment case arrested

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

The prime accused in the molestation and harassment of a Class 10 girl and her male friend was shot in the leg during a police encounter on Tuesday in Bihar’s Jamui district. Nandan Yadav sustained injuries in his leg during the encounter while co-accused Hare Ram Yadav injured his leg while trying to escape from the spot, police said.

Earlier on September 21, three minors were apprehended as accused in the incident. Ramshish Choudhary, who captured the act that went viral, was taken into custody on Tuesday morning, said police. “All persons involved in the incident have been arrested and local police are interrogating them,” said Additional Director General of Police (Law and Order) K.S. Anupam at the State police headquarters in Patna.

She confirmed that Nandan Yadav was the prime accused shown in the video with an orange towel wrapped around his face and groping the minor girl.



Security personnel carry an accused allegedly involved in the harassment of a boy and a girl in Jamui, after he was shot in leg. PTI

Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Kumar Choudhary said “all the accused persons involved in the incident have been identified” and assured everyone that “strict action will be taken against them”.

“The government is working to ensure that such incidents do not happen again,” said Minister for Information and Public Relations Shrawan Kumar.

While addressing the media in Jamui, Superintendent of Police (SP) Vishwajeet Dayal on Tuesday said five persons have been arrested in the case so far.

Nandan Yadav and Hare Ram Yadav, both 25, are from Pratappur village of Jamui district and said to be tractor drivers with a

history of involvement in illegal sand transportation, bootlegging and other illicit activities, he said.

Asked how the prime accused was arrested, the Jamui SP said: “... When police caught a man after a chase, he disclosed his name as Hare Ram Yadav and also told police that the other accused Nandan Yadav is hiding nearby. As police spotted Nandan Yadav hiding behind tall bushes and grass, he fired at the police and a brief exchange ensued following which he was arrested upon getting shot in the leg.”

The police officer said both the accused have been admitted in a town hospital.

Tejashwi says CM should stand by his word, resign

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Bihar’s Leader of Opposition Tejashwi Yadav on Tuesday demanded the resignation of Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary over the Jamui incident. Mr. Yadav asserted that Mr. Choudhary was not able to run the State, as law and order had collapsed. “The incident in Jamui has shamed Bihar and the nation. Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary had declared that he would resign immediately if such an incident involving women occurred anywhere in Bihar. If he stands by his word, he should resign,” Mr. Yadav said. He also criticised Janata Dal (United) State president Umesh Singh Kushwaha and Minister Shrawan Kumar, both of whom termed the incident *chitput ghatna* (sporadic incident).

An old video of Mr. Choudhary, dated September 29, 2025, has now gone viral, in which he says that if anyone returning home from the village at midnight is touched, he will resign the next morning.

Sharjeel Imam gets interim bail to attend kin’s wedding

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Tuesday granted interim bail to Sharjeel Imam, an accused in the case concerning the alleged larger conspiracy behind the 2020 northeast Delhi riots.

The Karkardooma Court granted him temporary release from October 4 to October 10 to enable him to attend his cousin’s wedding. The Delhi High Court is scheduled to hear his regular bail plea on September 30.

This is not the first time Mr. Imam has received interim relief. He was earlier granted a 10-day interim bail from March 20 to March 30 to attend his brother’s wedding.

Mr. Imam and several other student activists, including Umar Khalid, participated in protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) in 2019-2020.

On July 4, a Delhi court rejected the bail pleas of Mr. Khalid and Mr. Imam.

Wangchuk slams delay in making judicial panel report public

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Prominent activist and educator from Ladakh, Sonam Wangchuk on Tuesday said civil society groups would constitute a “people’s tribunal” to probe the “police excess and firing” which led to the death of four persons, including a Kargil war veteran, on September 24, 2025, if the government appointed judicial panel did not table its report soon.

Mr. Wangchuk alleged that automatic weapons were used against protesters despite there being no firing orders. He said the inquiry report was crucial to establish the circumstances that led to the firing and subsequent deaths and injuries.

Following the September 24, 2025 incident at Leh city, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) on October 17, 2025 notified a Judicial Inquiry to be conducted by Justice B.S Chauhan, former Judge of the Supreme Court. The mandate of the panel is to probe the circumstances leading to the serious law and order situation, the

police action and the resultant unfortunate death of the four individuals. [In February, Justice (retd.) Chauhan was also appointed head of the three-member Commission of Inquiry to probe the 2023 Manipur ethnic violence.]

In an interview with *The Hindu*, Mr. Wangchuk, who is now part of a high-powered committee to hold talks with the MHA to demand constitutional safeguards for Ladakh, said all affidavits and other submissions before the judicial inquiry had been completed long ago, but there was no indication about when its findings would be made public.

“That is a serious grievance in the martyrs’ memorial month. One year after the incident, we don’t even have justice for these martyrs. Who is right and who is wrong has to be cleared,” he said.

Mr. Wangchuk said he had not personally deposed before the inquiry as he was in jail when the proceedings were under way. “People here are saying maybe we should constitute an alternative judicial inquiry through respectable retired judges, a peo-



Sonam Wangchuk says automatic weapons were used against protesters without firing orders. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Activist says Ladakhi groups want all criminal cases against them to be withdrawn at once

ple’s tribunal kind of thing, because the government-instituted commission is just not coming out with the report,” he said.

One-day padayatra

He has announced a one-day, 20-km symbolic *padayatra* (footmarch) on September 23 to commemorate those killed in the violence and press for justice. The march would start from Karu, where vil-

lagers constructed a *stupa* in memory of one of those killed, and conclude at the Martyrs’ Memorial Park in Leh around 6 p.m. A longer march was abandoned because of inclement weather, he said.

Mr. Wangchuk also responded to former Bharatiya Janata Party MP Thupstan Chhewang’s recent allegation that he was “misleading” the people of Ladakh about the outcome of the September 9 meeting with the MHA. Mr. Wangchuk alleged that Mr. Chhewang had been “drifting away from the Ladakhi people’s stand and more towards the government stand” after resigning from

the Leh Apex Body (LAB). He said the former MP attended the meetings as a special invitee and did not represent the LAB.

Mr. Chhewang is among the first leaders in Ladakh to launch the movement in 2020 seeking constitutional safeguards for the region after Article 370 ceased to apply to the erstwhile State of Jammu and Kashmir, of which Ladakh was a part.

‘Insult to injury’

Mr. Wangchuk also criticised the compensation announced by the Union Territory administration for those killed and injured in the violence, describing it as inadequate. He said the civil society groups had sought substantially higher compensation for the victims.

“It has been seen more as insult to the injury, you know, ₹15 lakh for a person killed for no reason with no firing orders, and ₹3 lakh for injured. Whereas in Delhi, they have agreed to ₹1 crore compensation. So this is a serious grievance,” he said.

On the September 9 meeting between Ladakh representatives and the MHA, Mr. Wangchuk said

the Centre had reiterated its earlier proposals for a “*sui generis*”, or tailor-made, democratic arrangement for Ladakh and safeguards under Article 371 of the Constitution, which was a repetition of the proposal made on May 22 and that Ladakhi representatives were expecting the government to place detailed drafts before them in September.

“We had sent our non-negotiable points to be included in the draft. But on September 9, after all of us flew to Delhi, we discovered that it was just a PowerPoint presentation of what happened on May 22. There was hardly anything new,” Mr. Wangchuk said.

He alleged that the September meeting had been scheduled to dissuade people from participating in a *padayatra* that was to begin the following day. He similarly questioned the decision to hold the next round of talks in October, saying September was being observed in Ladakh as a month to commemorate those killed.

Mr. Wangchuk, however, said he hoped negotiations would now progress and that the proposed mo-

del of governance for Ladakh would be brought before the Parliament during its winter session.

Withdrawal of cases

On the administration’s announcement regarding the withdrawal of criminal cases registered following the violence, Mr. Wangchuk said Ladakhi groups wanted all cases to be withdrawn rather than their withdrawal in phases. He claimed that several people booked after the violence were bystanders or individuals who had attempted to stop the clashes.

The LAB and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) have been negotiating with the MHA over their demands for constitutional safeguards for Ladakh, greater political representation and protection of land and employment rights. Mr. Wangchuk said the two groups also wanted the administration to refrain from taking far-reaching decisions on land, industries and local governance while negotiations over a new political arrangement were under way.

To watch the interview, go to newsth.live/sonam

Siam to be next Bangladesh High Commissioner to India

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

The current Foreign Secretary of Bangladesh, Asad Alam Siam, will be the next High Commissioner of Bangladesh to India, diplomatic sources have confirmed. Bangladesh on Tuesday received the Indian diplomatic document – agrément – that will pave the way for Mr. Siam to take charge of the High Commission of Bangladesh in New Delhi in the coming weeks.

The appointment of Foreign Secretary Siam has taken place against the backdrop of negotiations between New Delhi and Dhaka for a possible India visit by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman sometime in November. Mr. Rahman was earlier invited to visit



Asad Alam Siam

Delhi for the BRICS summit, but the visit could not take place over tough exchanges that broke out after deposed Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina held a virtual press interaction on August 5.

Mr. Siam will succeed Riaz Hamidullah, who was posted here in 2025 during the interim administration headed by Prof. Mohammed Yunus. The 15-

month period under Prof. Yunus posed a challenge to bilateral relations, as relations remained caught in a cold frame over multiple issues including the presence of Ms. Hasina on Indian soil.

The coming months are crucial, as the year-end is when the three-decade-old Ganga Water Agreement is expected to expire, and both sides held a round of discussions earlier this year for renewal of the treaty, though the last phase of meetings is yet to be held.

Following the announcement of Mr. Siam’s appointment on Tuesday, the Official Spokesperson of the Ministry of External Affairs Randhir Jaiswal said, “We want positive, constructive and forward-looking ties with Bangladesh.”

4,812 books removed from college libraries: J&K govt. tells House

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Around 21.81 lakh books were screened, and 4,812 books withdrawn from government and private college libraries in the Union Territory this year, the Jammu and Kashmir government told the Assembly on Tuesday.

The government informed the House that 21.81 lakh books had been screened in college libraries since July, including 12.48 lakh books in the Kashmir division and 9.32 lakh in the Jammu division. Out of 4,812 books, 518 were banned books and 4,249 were non-banned books.

At least 1,752 books had been referred to the Direc-

tor, Colleges, for expert examination, it said.

“The process of scrutiny of objectionable books/material to be withdrawn is in progress in the Department as the same is a laborious exercise and may take more time,” it said. The government told the House that “clear and objective criteria” have been adopted for identifying objectionable material for scrutiny of books available in colleges.

The government’s reply came in response to a question from Awami Ittehad Party legislator Sheikh Khurshheed, who asked if there was a clear and objective criteria for identifying objectionable material through scrutiny of books available in colleges.

ED arrests one accused in case linked to trafficking of drugs

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has arrested an accused person under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, in connection with an international drug-trafficking case being probed by the National Investigation Agency (NIA). The syndicate was allegedly involved in large-scale import of heroin by concealing it in semi-processed talc stone consignments.

The ED has secured five-day custody of the accused, Gaurav Dawar, who was also allegedly linked to narcotics seizures across Delhi, Punjab, and Haryana.

The NIA, which has registered the case against Harpreet Singh Talwar and



others, had earlier filed six chargesheets and accused several persons of conspiring with an international drug smuggling syndicate operating from Afghanistan, Pakistan, and Dubai in the UAE.

The network operated under the “mastermind Vityash Koser alias Raju Dubai, a wanted accused, along with Pakistani ISI agents and Afghan nation-

als”. The NIA found that ₹74 crore generated from the illegal sale of narcotic drugs had been transferred via ‘hawala’ to Afghanistan. and used for funding terrorist activities.

“The ED investigation has revealed generation of proceeds of crime totalling ₹89 crore through contraband smuggling, distribution of drug proceeds, and ‘hawala’ operation, including the aforesaid ‘hawala’ of the ₹74 crore initially quantified by the NIA. Further investigation is under progress to identify additional proceeds of crime generated in this process,” the ED said on Tuesday.

According to the ED, the drug proceeds were systematically layered and integrated into commercial hospitality ventures, night clubs, and luxury assets.

Cong. slams
EC silence
on ‘attack’ on
party convoy

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Tuesday questioned the Election Commission’s silence regarding the alleged attack on a convoy carrying former Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel, who is also the All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary for Assam; State party chief Gaurav Gogoi; and other party leaders during campaigning for the bypoll in the Nagaon Lok Sabha seat. The party sought an independent probe into the incident.

The convoy faced stone-pelting in the Samaguri Assembly segment on Monday, which the Congress termed as a “planned murderous attack” aimed at intimidating its leaders and workers ahead of the October 6 bypoll. The party said acid had been thrown at the convoy and that masked assailants used iron rods in the attack. It also alleged that the incident had taken place despite the administration being alerted about the possibility of trouble.

Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh said the incident was not an isolated event but a “shameful attempt” by the BJP, with the “tacit approval” of the Election Commission, to avert a likely defeat by resorting to violence.

Notices for Delhi SIR
seem ‘mechanically
issued’, says top court

It asks poll body if recipients at least know what ‘logical discrepancies’ they have to resolve; vague notices risk disenfranchising lakhs, says petition

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said the notices sent by the Election Commission (EC) during the special intensive revision (SIR) in Delhi to over 33 lakh voters due to ‘logical discrepancies’ or ‘no mapping’ with previous electoral records seem to be “machine-generated” without any application of mind.

“Some refinement is necessary. These look like mechanically issued notices... Please examine if some additional filters are necessary,” Justice Joymaya Bagchi, part of a three-judge Bench with Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V. Mohana, addressed the EC counsel, senior advocate Dama Seshadri Naidu.

Justice Bagchi asked the EC if the people to whom these notices were sent at least knew what logical discrepancies they had to prove incorrect.

Mr. Naidu said the deadline for notice disposal was October 29. “But we are open to extension since it [Delhi] is not election-bound,” he submitted.



Voters who were issued notices appear for a hearing at a school in New Delhi on September 17. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

He assured the top court that not a single name would be deleted and reasons had been assigned in the notices sent to voters.

Advocates Prashant Bhushan and Neha Rathi and activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Amrita Johri referred to how 91% of the voters in West Bengal who appealed against the logical discrepancies had been added to the roll. “But the whole process of getting back into the electoral roll would take years,” Mr. Bhushan submitted.

The court said the Delhi SIR may need better orientation. Some key figures who were sent notices include External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal, current Chief Mi-

nister Rekha Gupta, former Deputy Prime Minister L.K. Advani and senior advocate Kapil Sibal.

The petition said the term ‘logical discrepancies’ was not defined by the EC. There were neither parameters to determine the circumstances in which an elector would fall within that category nor any document or instruction regarding this aspect posted on the website.

It contended that issuance of vague notices would make lakhs of electors vulnerable to an arbitrary process of potential disenfranchisement.

The court issued notice to the EC and sought a status report while listing the case for hearing after two weeks.

Conservationist wins *businessline*
Changemaker of the Year award

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In an inspiring ceremony charged with emotion, gripping stories of human achievement and a mellifluous classical fusion performance, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman presented *businessline*’s Changemaker of the Year award to grassroots conservationist Purnima Devi Barman for saving the endangered greater adjutant stork and empowering village women to become feisty protectors of the bird as well as self-reliant entrepreneurs.

Border Roads Organisation (BRO), which builds and maintains critical infrastructure in India’s remote border areas, was crowned Iconic Changemaker as was ‘pain doctor’ M.R. Rajagopal, founder and chairman emeritus of Pallium India, who integrated palliative care in mainstream healthcare services.

Receiving the award, Ms. Purnima Devi said, “When women rise, magic happens and the *hargila* (stork) takes flight.”

The eighth edition of the event saw awards being given in six categories – Digital Transformation, Social Transformation, Financial Transformation, Young Changemaker, Iconic Changemaker, and Changemaker of the Year. The Digital Transformation winner was Aparna Hegde,



Nirmala Sitharaman, Union Finance Minister; Raghuvir Srinivasan, Editor, *businessline*; and Nirmala Lakshman, Director and Publisher, The Hindu Group; pose with the awardees at the *businessline* Changemaker Awards ceremony in New Delhi on Tuesday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR



founder of ARMMAN (Advancing Reduction In Mortality and Morbidity of Mother, Children and Neonates), a non-profit that uses technology to reach out to expectant mothers and guide them.

In the Social Transformation category, there were two winners – Project Sambandh, founded by Colonel Vembu Shankar (retired), which helps families of armed forces personnel who die while in service but not in combat, and Sankara Eye Foundation for scaling up free eye care. Financial Transformation winner was

Gourmet Popcornica for building a fully-integrated farm-to-consumer value chain across several States and giving a pop to the popcorn economy. The Young Changemaker award went to Ariana Agarwal, a 16-year-old girl from Jaipur for giving visibility to invisible gig workers.

‘Making a difference’ Acknowledging *businessline*’s role in bringing to the fore the work of changemakers, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said: “India is a vast country. Despite the States and Centre doing so much, it is the changemakers who are putting their heart and soul in their endeavours, who are making a difference on the ground.”

Earlier, inaugurating the event, Nirmala Lakshman, Director, THG Publishing Private Ltd., said, “Every year, this evening gives us a chance to recognise the

power of an idea to create change...and the persistence to see this through.”

Raghuvir Srinivasan, Editor, *businessline*, described how 1,600 nominations were received, from which the winners were chosen – a really tough job for the jury. “It was like a *samudra manthan* (churning of the ocean),” he said.

The 2026 awards function was presented by Sasthra Deemed University and powered by City Union Bank. Associate partners were State Bank of India, Life Insurance Corporation, Government of Andhra Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh Industrial Infrastructure Corporation, Citizen Watches, Government of Uttarakhand, Jammu & Kashmir Bank, NABARD, NTPC, Indian Bank, SAIL, GAIL (India) Limited, Essar Group, ICFAI Group, NMDC, and UCO Bank. The mobility partner was Kia Sorento.

At UN summit, Jaishankar calls for reformed multilateralism

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

India has co-sponsored an inaugural multilateralism summit at the UN “at a time when the global order is under stress”, as New Delhi asserts that more participative deliberations and transparent decision-making are overdue.

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Monday co-chaired the first-ever ‘Partners for Multilateralism, International Law, Peace & Prosperity (P4M)’ Summit held on the margins of the high-level 81st session of the UN General Assembly, along with lead-

ers of Australia, Barbados, Brazil, Canada and Kenya.

“India is glad to join as a co-sponsor. We meet at a time when the global order is under stress,” Mr. Jaishankar said in his remarks at the summit held in the UN headquarters.

He said that for some decades, the world had witnessed a steady rebalancing, which was a long-expected structural evolution.

“However, extreme competition, geopolitical tensions and actual conflicts have given this an entirely different character. If left unchecked, it would call into question the very



S. Jaishankar greets European Council President António Costa at the first ever P4M summit in New York on Monday. @DRSJAISHANKAR/X

spirit of international cooperation, and that is why it is so essential that multilateralism asserts itself strongly at this juncture,” he said.

He told the summit that where ongoing conflicts

were concerned, specific dimensions could be addressed even while nations strived for a broader peace. “The ‘4F’ crisis of fuel, food, fertilizer and finance cannot be left to itself. When new capabilities

and concerns arise, there is a very powerful case for frameworks and guardrails. Where there is a threat of chokepoint dominance and disruption, de-risking and diversifying must be encouraged.” “And where there is a compelling cause or a powerful case, the like-minded must have the confidence to come together,” he said.

He was joined by the summit’s cosponsors – President of the European Council António Costa, President of Kenya William Ruto, Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese, Barbados Prime Minister Mia Mottley, Brazilian Mi-

nister of Foreign Affairs Mauro Vieira and Canadian Permanent Representative David Lametti, who read remarks on behalf of Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney.

He stressed that multilateralism would be best served when international law, rules and norms were scrupulously observed. He said, “For multilateralism to forge ahead, its advocacy and its practice must both be strengthened. Reformed multilateralism is therefore essential. More participative deliberations and more transparent decision-making are both overdue.”

Packed schedule for
Jaishankar at UN as
India campaigns for
Security Council spot

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India on Monday joined the Partnership for Multilateralism, endorsing the “non-superpower” grouping originally launched by the European Union (EU), Brazil, Canada and Kenya, and became an additional co-sponsor of the initiative along with Australia and Barbados.

The meeting of the grouping, called P4M, which is expected to build support for the United Nations and multilateralism,

was one of several bilateral and multilateral meetings External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar took part in as he and the Indian delegation navigate a tough task list this week at the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA). On top of Mr. Jaishankar’s agenda, this year is to garner support for India at next year’s election for the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) non-permanent membership for the 2028-2029 period.

Within a few hours of landing in New York on Monday (September 21), Mr. Jaishankar met with Foreign Ministers from France, Ecuador, Slovakia, Hungary, Ukraine, Moldova, and Switzerland. He also met the President of Naoero (Nauru), participated in the P4M meeting, had another meeting with EU ministers, and attended an India-Visegrad group meeting with the Central European nations of Poland, Hungary, Slovakia and Czechia. On Tuesday he began his meetings with the 33-member Community of Latin American and Caribbean States (CELAC).

The meetings with European leaders, as well as

expected meetings this week with his counterparts from the United States and Canada, are also expected to prepare for Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s upcoming visits to Brussels, Miami and Ottawa in December. Officials say the rest of the External Affairs Minister’s schedule this week – he is expected to remain in New York until he addresses the General Assembly on Saturday – will be equally packed for multiple reasons.

UNSC push India has thus far been elected to the UNSC eight times, and on most occasions, has been the single name put forward for the Asia-Pacific group. However, this time, Tajikistan has also launched its candidature for the seat, and unless New Delhi can ensure a compromise, convincing the Tajik government to step aside in exchange for support for a future election, this will turn into a contest for the Asian seat.

As a result, all eyes will be on any meeting between Mr. Jaishankar and the Tajikistan Foreign Minister, Sirojiddin Muhriddin. In addition, Mr. Jaishankar’s meetings with Ministers from other Central Asian countries, as well as from other parts of the Global South, will also be watched for any announcements of support for India’s candidature. On the sidelines of the SCO Summit in Bishkek earlier this month, Mr. Modi held a meeting with Tajikistan President Emomali Rahmon. However, External Affairs Ministry officials said they could not confirm whether Mr. Modi had received any assurance from Mr. Rahmon regarding the UNSC seat.

BJP questions Cong.
after court order on
Sonia’s voter roll entry

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The BJP attacked the Congress on Tuesday, a day after a Delhi court set aside a Magistrate’s order refusing to inquire into a complaint alleging that senior Congress leader Sonia Gandhi’s name appeared on the electoral roll in 1980, three years before she became an Indian citizen.

The court has remanded the matter back to the Magistrate court to pass a reasoned order after hearing fresh arguments.

At a press conference on Tuesday, BJP spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari asked if there were any irregularities in the inclusion of Ms. Gandhi’s name in the electoral roll in 1980. Stating that such an action was a violation of Article 326 of the Constitution and the Representation of the People Act, he said it was also a cognisable offence.

Mr. Bhandari said Ms. Gandhi was not an Indian citizen in 1980 and ques-

A complaint alleged that Sonia Gandhi’s name appeared on the roll three years before she became an Indian citizen

tioned whether there had been an “attempt to forge documents, given that the Congress was in power from 1980 to 1983”.

“There can be no greater theft of democracy than this, because on the one hand, they support infiltrators in the name of opposing the SIR (Special Intensive Revision), while on the other hand, when they themselves allegedly steal democracy through forged documents, they remain silent,” he alleged, seeking a clarification from Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi.

“If Rahul Gandhi does not answer all these questions, the people of the country and the youth will understand his silence as an admission of guilt,” said Mr. Bhandari.

Big players will invest in West Bengal
for the love of the country: Adhikari

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Stating that he was receiving support from across the country to revive industry in West Bengal, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Tuesday expressed hope that big players would invest in the State for the love of the country.

“There will be investment in Bengal. All the big players will invest in the State for the love of the country, and to revive the State. The manner in which the communists and Mamata (former CM Mamata Banerjee) destroyed West Bengal, the entire country is willing to revive the State. I have received this commitment from everywhere,” Mr. Adhikari told media persons in Cooch Behar.

The Chief Minister also recalled his meeting with the chairman of Reliance Industries Limited Mukesh Ambani in Mumbai on Monday (September 21, 2026), adding that he had



West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari with Reliance Industries Limited chairperson Mukesh Ambani and director Anant Ambani. ANI

visited an event held by Mr. Mukesh Ambani’s son Anant Ambani. Mr. Adhikari posted on social media that he had “exchanged thoughts on the immense possibilities for industrial growth and employment generation in West Bengal” with Mr. Mukesh Ambani.

“Our State is ready to welcome visionary investments that empower our youth and drive sustainable economic resurgence,” he said. He also thanked Mr. Mukesh Ambani, his wife Nita Ambani, and the entire Ambani family for their hospitality, describing the welcome as one of

“extraordinary warmth and gracious hospitality”.

On September 24, Adani Group chairperson Mr. Gautam Adani will be visiting Kolkata to lay the foundation stone of a 2,000-bed hospital, Mr. Adhikari said.

Mr. Adani is likely to kick off three major projects in West Bengal on September 24, including the renovation of Writers’ Buildings and the redevelopment of the Kumartuli ghat in north Kolkata.

One of the biggest challenges before the incumbent Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government is ena-

INBRIEF



‘Broad daylight dacoity’: SC on essential cancer drugs’ prices

Terming it a “broad daylight dacoity” against patients, the Supreme Court on Tuesday expressed shock over the overpricing of essential cancer medicines, noting that one drug carried an MRP of ₹27,000 despite being supplied to retailers for ₹2,700. “It is very surprising that the authorities who are supposed to take action on this are silent,” a Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said. The observations came when the court was hearing two petitions on drug-related issues, including that of ensuring strict price control over medicines. “The MRP is 10 times the rate at which it is provided to the retailers. If this is not extortion, then what it is?,” the Bench observed. PTI

Regulator warns against careless use of antibiotics

The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) has cautioned against the indiscriminate or prolonged use of painkillers and antibiotics, citing the associated risk of kidney damage. In a circular dated September 21, the regulator said non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs and antibiotics are regulated under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940 and the Drugs Rules, 1945, and should be sold on the prescription of a registered medical practitioner. The regulator advised the public not to self-medicate with antibiotics or use them for conditions where they are not clinically indicated, including most uncomplicated viral infections.

IIT-B student’s parents seek arrest of faculty member

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

Days after a 22-year-old student of the Indian Institute of Technology, Bombay was found dead in his hostel room, his parents have demanded the arrest of a faculty member and the institute’s director, alleging that their son had been threatened and subjected to casteist abuse.

Sahil Wakode, a second-year B.Tech. student in the Department of Energy Science and Engineering, was found dead on Friday, hours after he was allegedly found using ChatGPT on his phone during an exam.

The next day, the Powai police registered a first information report (FIR) under charges including abetment of suicide and Sections of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

‘Please ensure justice. Why is it that Dalit students are the ones committing suicide?’

The FIR, filed on the basis of a complaint by the student’s father, Ravindra Wakode, named faculty member Suryanarayana Doolla.

Addressing a press conference on Tuesday, Mr. Wakode said his son had told him that Professor Doolla allegedly used casteist slurs against him for three months and that the faculty member threatened to implicate him in false cases. According to the father, his son further alleged that the faculty member was acting on the instructions of the director of the institute.

The student’s mother, Sonali Wakode, said the fa-

mily visited him on September 13, when he told them about the alleged harassment he was facing.

“Please ensure justice. Why is it that Dalit students are the ones committing suicide? We supported him mentally, telling him, ‘Your future is bright, son; just endure this.’ That was our mistake. If we had taken him away that day, my child would be alive today,” she said.

She also said that during their visit, her son had told them that he was being “tortured” and that he was facing casteist slurs.

Meanwhile, the police on Tuesday detained dozens of activists belonging to the Republican Party of India (A) and Bharat Mukti Morcha after they staged a protest outside the IIT main gate over the death.

(For those in distress, counselling is available at Tele MANAS 14416)

Congress accuses govt. of hiding IIT student suicide data

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Tuesday alleged that the government had withheld data on suicides at the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs).

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal alleged that the Education Ministry had deliberately excluded suicide-related data from its response to a parliamentary question he had raised in December 2025.

“When I raised this question in Parliament, the Ministry gave a vague response and evaded disclosing specific numbers,” Mr. Venugopal said in an X post. He said an Under Secretary in the Ministry had written to the IITs on December 1, 2025, seeking the relevant information,

but the data were not included in the Minister’s response.

“This shows that their intentions were to lie to the people, to hide the extent of discrimination taking place at elite government institutions,” Mr. Venugopal alleged. He was reacting to a news report which claimed that 53 students had died by suicide at the IITs over the past five years and that more than 50% of them belonged to the Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Classes.

He linked the issue to the death of Sahil Wakode, who was from an SC community and a student of the IIT-Bombay, and demanded an explanation from the government on why the data were not disclosed.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14905

(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

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Across

8 Emperor's generous to some extent (4)

9 Girl with Ralph drops student's diagram (5)

10 Finished 6 balls (4)

11 To push wildly and get effect (6)

12 Tour permits 3 kids born to the same mother at the same time (8)

13 One who sets free sub-letter? (8)

15 Mixed broth shakes finally and pulsates (6)

17 Alien in print media fixes in advance (7)

19 Once again corrects article from mistaken dieters (2-5)

22 Guy at the Spanish place of worship (6)

24 Old boy with European saint turned out to be respectful (8)

26 Concentrated bombardments for dams (8)

28 Angry boss accepts note (6)

30 Part of body found in Washington (4)

31 Athletic Australian soldier starting to like expedition (5)

32 Something for holding cold sauce (4)

Down

1 That chap gets a penny for stack (4)

2 Female feline, having lost eye, I hear, carries child in legendary creature's lair (4,4)

3 Stones silver seat at random (6)

4 Pound Yankee's source of power (7)

5 Author Agatha organised charities without American capital (8)

6 Elbow broken by regiment's cricket player (6)

7 Singlet from Galveston (4)

14 Mud in possession of Uncle Arthur (5)

16 Conductor's club? (5)

18 Excitedly melt gear to produce wire (8)

20 Send Chinese after German row (8)

21 Adore women with gold on vessel (7)

23 Apparently includes immediate ancestor (6)

25 Repeats E, E, E, ..., for radioman around end of sortie (6)

27 A revolutionary's pain (4)

29 Give out wrong item (4)

SUDOKU

	8			6	7		3
3							
9	7	2			8	6	
				8	3		1
			2		4		
2	5		9	1			
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6		4	5			7	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

T	E	R	A	B	E	N	O	M
A	S	I	A	B	E	N	O	M
A	I	T	E	N	T	A		
W	R	E	N	C	H	I	G	V
E	A	B	E	I				
B	O	N	E	V	A	R	E	
G	A	R	I	N	G	R	E	P
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U	R	D	A					
Z	I	N	C	B	O	W	I	E
N	E	E	S	D	S	L		

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

3	8	1	5	9	4	6	2	7
9	4	5	6	7	2	3	1	8
2	6	7	8	1	3	5	9	4
1	7	9	2	3	5	8	4	6
6	3	4	7	8	9	2	5	1
5	2	8	4	6	1	9	7	3
8	5	2	3	4	7	1	6	9
4	1	6	9	2	8	7	3	5
7	9	3	1	5	6	4	8	2

FAITH
The giant form of Vamana

The story of Lord Vamana and King Mahabali is narrated in the eighth canto of the Srimad Bhagavata Purana, said Tirukudanthai Dr. Venkatesh in a discourse.

Asura king Mahabali performed the powerful Vishwajit Yajna under his guru Shukracharya's guidance. Strengthened by these blessings, Mahabali conquered Swarga Loka and drove out Indra and the devas from heaven.

Distressed by the defeat of her sons, Aditi (Indra's mother) sought guidance from her husband, sage Kashyapa. She observed the 12-day Payovrata with great devotion and prayed to Lord Vishnu. Pleased with her devotion, Lord Vishnu promised to be born as her son and appeared as Vamana, a radiant young Brahmachari.

Vamana later arrived at Mahabali's grand yajna. Welcoming him with reverence, Mahabali offered to grant whatever he desired. Vamana asked for only three feet of land. Shukracharya immediately recognised Vamana as Lord Vishnu and warned Mahabali that he would lose everything. Yet Mahabali refused to break his promise, valuing truth and dharma above wealth and power.

At once, Vamana assumed the magnificent Trivikrama form. With one step he covered the earth, and with the second he encompassed the heavens. With nowhere left for the third step, Mahabali bowed his head in complete surrender and offered himself. The Lord placed his foot upon Mahabali and sent him to Sutala Loka, a glorious realm even greater than Swarga. Deeply pleased with Mahabali's humility, devotion and steadfast truthfulness, Lord Vishnu promised to guard Sutala Loka and blessed Mahabali to become Indra in a future Manvantara.

Press Trust of India
GUJARAT

President Droupadi Murmu on Tuesday urged popular film artistes not to endorse products harmful to people's health, saying a “true star” spreads light, not darkness, highlighting the impact of words and actions of celebrities on young minds.

Ms. Murmu distributed the 72nd National Film Awards for 2024 in various categories of cinema at Ekta Nagar (Kevadia), near the Statue of Unity, in a glittering ceremony.

“When successful artistes speak about the benefits of a disciplined lifestyle, millions of children and young people emulate them. I urge popular artistes not to endorse products that are harmful to people's health. A true star is the one who spreads light, not darkness,” Ms. Murmu said. Highly popular artistes possessed immense potential to influence citizens, especially the youth, she said.

The President also called for greater participation of women on juries selecting films for the National Film Awards.

She appealed to the film industry to ensure respect and social security for

workers, small-scale artistes, assistants, and others who contribute to the creative economy while struggling to make their mark.

Ms. Murmu recalled that at the previous National Film Awards ceremony, she had urged the industry to make respect and sensitivity towards every member of the film crew an integral part of its work

culture. “I hope you are paying heed to these requests,” she said.

‘Illustrious journey’ Veteran Kannada actor Anant Nag received the prestigious Dadasaheb Phalke award, the highest honour in cinema, “for his contribution to Indian cinema and an illustrious cinematic journey that has inspired generations”.

Mammootty's win for *Bramayugam* was a record-equalling fourth, placing him alongside veteran Amitabh Bachchan. In the su-

pernatural drama directed by Rahul Sadasivan, Mammootty played the role of Kodumon Potty, a malicious and powerful spirit.

While Ms. Gautam grabbed the best actor award for her role in *Article 370*, Mr. Aaryan won the award for his portrayal of Paralympian gold medalist Murlikant Petkar in the film *Chandu Champion*.

Tamil actor Dhanush



Starry event: President Droupadi Murmu presents the Dadasaheb Phalke Award to veteran actor Anant Nag and the National Awards to Yami Gautam, Dhanush, Mammootty, and Kartik Aaryan at Kevadia in Narmada district of Gujarat on Tuesday. ANI/ PTI

was honoured with a Special Mention for his performance in the period drama *Captain Miller*.

Actor-turned-director Randeep Hooda took home the Best Debut Film of a Director award for *Swatantrya Veer Savarkar*. Rajkumar Periasamy received the Best Direction award for the Tamil movie *Amaran*.

Bhangaar, directed and produced by Sumira Roy, got the Best Non-Feature Film award. Sanjeev Shrivastava received the Best Film Critic award in Hindi.

Sachana Namidass received the Best Actress in a Supporting Role award for the Tamil movie *Maharaja*, while Ropashree Varkady received the second Best Actress in a Supporting Role award for the Kannada movie *Mithya*.

Telugu film *Pushpa: The Rule* was given the Best Costume Design award, while Sukumar received the Best Screenplay award for the film. R Kalaivannan bagged the Best Editing award for the Tamil movie *Amaran*.

Shashwat Sachdev of *Dhurandhar* fame received the Best Music Direction award for songs in *Article 370*, while G.V. Prakash Kumar was honoured for the background music of *Amaran*.



Hardeep Singh Puri is among the retiring MPs. ANI

due next year. In Uttarakhand, BJP MP Naresh Bansal's term is coming to an end.

BJP to gain Bengal seat

The West Bengal bypoll was necessitated by the resignation of former Trinamool Congress MP Rukmini Mallik, an actor popularly known as Koel Mallick, on July 16, just three months after she was sworn in to the Rajya Sabha. The winner of the bypoll will serve the remainder of the term until April 2, 2032.

These elections will likely result in only minor changes in the party composition of the Rajya Sabha, with only the BJP set to gain one seat with a win in West Bengal at the cost of the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress.

The BJP is also comfortably placed to retain the Uttarakhand seat.

India’s vast canal network offers a land-free path to solar power

Similar to floating solar, the biggest advantage of canal-top photovoltaics is that they require virtually no additional land, especially as land acquisition for large-scale solar is also becoming increasingly expensive; in Punjab, the installation of 20 MW of canal-top systems is estimated to have saved nearly 100 acres of land

Shantanu Roy

As India expands its clean energy capacity, finding land for solar projects is becoming a challenge. This is driving interest in innovative solar solutions that can generate power without needing more land.

The recently approved PM Surya Sarovar Yojana (PM-SSY) is a step in this direction, aiming at developing 5,000 MW of floating solar capacity on reservoirs and other inland water bodies across the country.

However, India’s water infrastructure has more to offer: the country’s vast canal network – one of the largest in the world – is another under-explored avenue to generate solar power. Built over existing irrigation and water-supply canals, canal-top photovoltaics (CTPV) provides a unique approach to turn them into clean energy assets.

In CTPV, solar panels are mounted on specialised structures built over canal stretches. Unlike floating solar systems, where panels are installed on floating platforms on water bodies, CTPV systems use elevated structures above the canals.

Systems can be built based on the canal’s width, design, and orientation. The elevated structures may span the canal or can be installed along the canal banks. In all cases, the design must allow unobstructed water flow.

Advantages of CTPV

Similar to floating solar, the biggest advantage of CTPV is that it requires virtually no additional land. With land acquisition for large-scale solar becoming increasingly challenging and expensive, CTPV offers a promising way by using India’s canal infrastructure. For instance, in Punjab, the installation of 20 MW of CTPV systems is estimated to have saved nearly 100 acres of land.

CTPV offers another advantage. With solar panels covering canal stretches, the amount of water lost to evaporation can be reduced. This can be particularly useful in India’s water-stressed regions. The cooling effect of the water beneath the panels could improve panel performance in hot weather. A 1-MW CTPV system over the Narmada Canal in Mehsana, Gujarat, commissioned in 2012, reportedly saves close to 9 million litres of water every year while generating 1.6 million units of electricity annually.

While CTPV remains largely a niche application, India has been an early adopter, with its first installation in Mehsana in 2012. Between 2014 and 2017, two 10-MW CTPV systems were commissioned in Vadodara, Gujarat, and 20 MW of CTPV systems were commissioned in Punjab between 2017 and 2018.



Solar panels seen installed above the Narmada canal in Chandrasan village, Gujarat, in 2012. The State hosted India’s first canal-top photovoltaics. AP

In September 2025, the Punjab Energy Development Agency invited ‘expressions of interest’ for 40-MW CTPV projects across Punjab’s canal network, spanning over 10,000 km. Haryana has also initiated efforts to explore CTPV systems over six of its irrigation canals.

CTPV also received policy support in 2014, when the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) launched a pilot-cum-demonstration scheme for grid-connected CTPV and canal bank projects with a target of 50 MW each for CTPV and canal-bank projects. The scheme also included financial assistance of Rs 3 crore and Rs 1.5 crore per MW or 30% of project cost, whichever was lower, for CTPV and canal bank systems, respectively.

An assessment in 2024 (co-authored by CSTEP, where the author works) estimated India’s CTPV and canal bank potential at around 131 GW (for canals up to 30 m wide and vertical bifacial

installations for canals over 30 m wide). Considerations such as solar irradiation, canal characteristics, distance from substations, and protected areas were included in the assessment to identify the best-suited canal stretches across India. The five States with the highest potential were Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Punjab.

Potential roadblocks

Despite India’s early progress, deployment has remained limited for more than a decade after the first installation.

High system cost is the primary bottleneck. CTPV systems are more expensive than ground-mounted ones as they require elevated structures to span canal stretches. These structures need to be designed to not disrupt canal operations and be sturdy enough to withstand winds. They also need additional structural steel, foundations,

and access provisions for operations and maintenance, all of which add to the overall costs.

Maintenance tasks, including cleaning panels and replacement and repair work, can also prove difficult when the structures are elevated above a working canal.

The linear nature of CTPV systems, which run along the course of canals, can also pose challenges when canals follow irregular paths or change direction. This can increase the cost of producing electricity, especially when electrical substations or transformers are not strategically located.

Renewed policy approach

PM-SSY is expected to revitalise the floating solar segment and drive its adoption across India, signalling growing policy interest in exploring land-neutral solar applications. This focus could extend to other solutions like CTPV, potentially giving the technology greater policy attention and momentum.

However, to overcome the aforementioned structural challenges and scale CTPV deployment, identifying and prioritising suitable canal stretches will be critical. Factors such as land scarcity, nearby electricity demand and grid connectivity, and canal orientation and geometry should be considered while selecting sites to maximise the economic viability of CTPV systems.

CTPV also requires accessible and tailored financing mechanisms, including viability gap funding and low-cost debt, to make it an attractive option for developers. This will help support early projects, allowing developers to build experience and eventually reducing costs through scale and standardisation.

However, the 2014 MNRE scheme on CTPV shows that financial support alone may not suffice to convert pilots into large-scale deployment.

A renewed policy approach that includes financial assistance and standardised specifications and guidelines, capacity building of state nodal agencies, irrigation departments, and other concerned agencies, and streamlined process flows is required.

While CTPV may not fully substitute ground-mounted or rooftop solar, they offer an untapped opportunity for India’s renewable energy expansion. Even if a fraction of CTPV’s technical potential is realised, it could significantly boost India’s renewable energy capacity without adding to the pressure on land resources.

(Shantanu Roy is the Sector Coordinator for Renewables and Energy Conservation at the Center for Study of Science, Technology and Policy (CSTEP), a research-based think tank. shantanu@cstep.in)

THE GIST

▼ In CTPV, solar panels are mounted on specialised structures built over canal stretches

▼ Systems can be built based on the canal’s width, design, and orientation and elevated structures may span the canal or can be installed along the canal banks

▼ With solar panels covering canal stretches, the amount of water lost to evaporation can be reduced, which can be particularly useful in India’s water-stressed regions

BIG SHOT



Winter retreat: Alpacas (*Lama pacos*) follow a shepherd down from mountain pastures to the valley ahead of the winter in Griesalp aera above Kiental in Switzerland on Tuesday. Around seventy alpacas were herded down to the valley before being transported to their winter farm located in Aeschi near Spiez, in the Swiss Bernese Oberland. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

AI doomsaying

Agence France-Presse

Several experts on a United Nations artificial intelligence committee have warned against the apocalyptic rhetoric used by some professionals in the sector regarding AI risks.

“As scientists, it’s very important to invest in the science, to really understand what we know (from) what we don’t know, and investing in fear is not that helpful,” said Joelle Barral, an executive at Google DeepMind and a member of the International Scientific Panel on AI, an independent body.

Former Anthropic employee Jacob Coxon, who previously worked at OpenAI, said in early September that AI developers believed the technology “could kill us all by the end of the decade”. A research engineer who left Google DeepMind in July made similar comments, saying it might already be “too late to avoid” humanity’s eradication by AI.

“We have to change the way we talk about AI risk because for a very long time, it’s either existential and everything is going to die and the killer robots are coming, or it doesn’t really matter,” Nobel Peace Prize laureate Maria Ressa, an investigative reporter, said at the same event, held in New York on September 21 on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly.

The International Scientific Panel on AI was created in 2025, with its members selected in February 2026. Its mandate is to advance the scientific understanding



An ‘emergency protest’ held by civic action group PauseAI UK outside Downing Street in central London on September 16. AFP

of AI and inform UN deliberations. Yoshua Bengio, considered one of the fathers of AI and a co-chair of the panel, said it was important to distinguish between what scientists actually know about AI risks and what can only be “plausibly extrapolated” from that evidence.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



Freezing democracy

The ECI is functioning as a tool of the Bharatiya Janata Party in West Bengal

Almost 28 years after Mamata Banerjee set up the All India Trinamool Congress and designed its symbol of ‘grass and flowers’, the Election Commission of India (ECI) on September 17, 2026, froze the party’s name and symbol. The 14-page order stated that since two rival groups – one led by Ms. Banerjee and the other by Arup Roy – are now claiming to be the party, the matter requires “substantive determination”, and neither group can use the party’s name or symbol. The ECI has allotted new names and symbols to both groups. The ECI’s move has effectively denied Ms. Banerjee of her party’s name and symbol. For nearly three decades, crores of voters have placed their faith in the party’s name and symbol, elected Ms. Banerjee as Chief Minister of West Bengal three times, and sent scores as its MPs to Parliament. Even in the April 2026 West Bengal Assembly polls, 41% of the electorate, or more than 2.60 crore voters, voted for Ms. Banerjee’s party, while the margin between it and the Bharatiya Janata Party was only about 32 lakh votes. Opposition parties, including the Congress, have said that similar attempts to freeze the name and symbol were made in the case of the Shiv Sena, calling such action of freezing the name and the symbol as “party theft” and a case of democratic decline.

Political parties are organic entities that keep democracy vibrant and alive and any attempts to engineer their dissolution is an attack on the very foundations of India’s democracy. If a political party has to wither away, it should happen only through the determination of the people. Serious questions have been raised about the role of the ECI, which held the West Bengal Assembly polls in 2026 after a hurriedly organised Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls that left lakhs of voters out, and is now freezing the name and symbol of the principal Opposition party. Free and fair elections form the bedrock of the republic. When political parties, which are engines for ensuring that the will of the electorate is reflected through free and fair elections, are dismantled and stripped of their names and symbols, the ECI cannot absolve itself of responsibility or hide behind processes and practices. The BJP leadership in West Bengal has repeatedly claimed that, after the Assembly polls, there would be no existence of the Trinamool Congress as a party. The ECI’s acts of omission and commission clearly suggest that it is acting in tandem with the interests of the BJP.

Water wealth

Groundwater exploitation in Punjab disincentivises small farmers

That Punjab is over-extracting groundwater is not news. According to the 2025-26 Dynamic Groundwater Assessment, its groundwater extraction rate was 152%. While interventions reduced the number of ‘over-exploited’ blocks by five over the last two assessments, 72% of its 153 blocks are in the ‘red zone’, the highest among States. The principal consumer is irrigation for rice and wheat, amounting to nearly 25 billion cubic metres a year in the latest estimate. Data also show that the fraction of observation wells with water below 40 metres in the post-monsoon period grew by two percentage points between 2022 and 2025. What began as a strategy to improve food security eventually yielded a concentrated rice-wheat cropping system, in which assured procurement, subsidised electricity and access to groundwater made high-yield varieties, intensive irrigation and fertilizer use and mechanisation less risky than alternative modes of cultivation. In the same vein, the reluctance of the region’s farmers to pursue other crops due to uncertainties in storage options, prices, processing infrastructure, and supply chains has gone relatively unaddressed. But as the water crisis persists, the wealth gap among farmers is also widening. A recent study in the *Economic and Political Weekly* noted that while farmers with marginal landholdings use water more efficiently, wealthier farmers are better equipped to access lower water tables as well as draw higher volumes. So, as the water table drops, those unable to afford the requisite tube wells are forced to buy water, transferring their wealth to larger landowners and creating unregulated dependencies. A different study by two members of the same team, published in *Discover Sustainability*, reported that in Sangrur and Barnala, larger farms earned higher returns but recorded lower groundwater productivity *vis-à-vis* paddy, than smaller farms. Effectively, groundwater depletion raises the capital required for irrigation, which systematically privileges those farmers with better access to finance.

State governments continue to attempt to address the demand pressure in multiple ways even as the scale continues to overwhelm the resulting gains in efficiency. At this juncture, together with those efforts, the State should also endeavour to protect farmers’ incomes and access to irrigation while rendering the cost of additional extraction prohibitive. The ‘*Pani Bachao, Paisa Kamao*’ scheme, in which farmers are entitled to cash for every unused kilowatt-hour (for pumping) under a threshold, is already promising, albeit with low enrolment. Broadly, the State should use part of the electricity subsidy bill to directly support smallholder farmers, help collectivise irrigation infrastructure, and/or support farmers’ transition to other crops. When benefits follow the cultivator, including tenants, rather than owners of the land or pumps, welfare can subsidise access to water rather than groundwater extraction.

The September 23, 1918 Battle of Haifa occupies a curious place in the intertwined histories of India, Israel, and Palestine. What was, in military terms, a small but tactically significant cavalry action in the final phase of the First World War has, over the past century, become a site of layered remembrance, celebrated, contested, reclaimed, and reinterpreted by different communities for different purposes. Remembering Haifa today requires navigating not only the battlefield itself but also the shifting terrain of postcolonial identity, diplomatic symbolism, and the moral ambiguities of imperial history.

For India, Haifa is often invoked as a symbol of the extraordinary global footprint of Indian soldiers during the First World War. More than a million Indians served overseas, from Flanders to Mesopotamia, and over 74,000 died in a war not of their own making. The cavalry charge at Haifa, executed by the Jodhpur, Mysore, and Hyderabad Lancers, stands out as one of the most dramatic episodes of Indian valour abroad. Contemporary British war diaries describe the action as decisive in securing the port city and enabling the Allied advance northwards to Damascus. It was also, for military buffs, one of the last great cavalry charges, and featured the 15th Imperial Service Cavalry Brigade which overcame principally Ottoman forces. The complication is that the Indian forces were under British command – and many Palestinian Arabs were on the side of the Ottomans.

Reclaiming military history

In the decades since Independence, Haifa has become part of a broader effort to reclaim India’s military history from the shadow of the empire. The soldiers who fought there were colonial subjects, but their courage and sacrifice belong to India’s national story. Commemorating Haifa thus becomes an act of historical recovery: an assertion that Indian agency existed even within the constraints of imperial command.

The Haifa narrative also illustrates how postcolonial nations reinterpret their pasts to assert dignity and continuity. For India, celebrating the battle (and renaming a First World War memorial as “Teen Murti Haifa Chowk”) is a way of acknowledging that its soldiers shaped world events long before the country became a sovereign republic. For Israel, the memory of Indian cavalry “liberating” Haifa has been woven into a narrative of gratitude and friendship, symbolised by memorials and annual ceremonies. These commemorations serve diplomatic purposes, but they also reflect a genuine historical connection.

Yet, this reclamation of agency is complicated by the fact that the soldiers themselves had no say in the political consequences of their actions.



Shashi Tharoor

Fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram (Congress party), the Chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs, and the Sahitya Akademi Award-winning author of 29 books, including ‘An Era of Darkness: The British Empire in India’

As a diplomatic bridge

In recent decades, Haifa has acquired new significance as a symbol of India-Israel friendship. Indian leaders have visited the Haifa memorial; Israeli officials have spoken warmly of the Indian role in the city’s history. These gestures reflect the deepening strategic partnership between the two countries, but they also demonstrate how historical memory can be mobilised to strengthen contemporary ties.

At the same time, this diplomatic embrace has sparked debate among historians. Some Israeli scholars argue that the Indian role has been overstated, and that the real credit should go to the British and Australian soldiers, a view that partially reflects their discomfort at “owing” much to colonised brown-skinned cavalymen. Meanwhile, Indian military historians point to British war records that clearly credit the Indian cavalry with the decisive breakthrough. These disagreements are not merely academic; they reflect the politics of national pride and the desire to shape historical narratives in ways that reinforce present-day identities.

The Palestinian critique of the Haifa narrative adds another layer of complexity. For Palestinians, the 1918 campaign is part of a longer story of foreign domination and displacement. From their perspective, the Indian cavalry’s victory facilitated British rule and the subsequent transformations that reshaped their homeland. This view does not diminish the bravery of Indian soldiers, but it challenges celebratory narratives that ignore the lived experience of those who were “liberated”. To many Palestinians, Indians

The Battle of Haifa represents India’s global military legacy, even as it lays bare the moral complexities of the empire

Using trade treaty policy to strengthen arbitration

India’s long-standing negotiations to sign new bilateral investment treaties (BITs) and free trade agreements (FTAs) with its prominent economic partners are bearing fruit. It has signed BITs with the United Arab Emirates (2024), Israel (2025), and Uzbekistan (2024), and FTAs with New Zealand (April 2026), the United Kingdom (July 2025), European Free Trade Association (March 2024), and Oman (signed December 2025). While much of the conversation has understandably focused on the potential economic benefits of these agreements and the mechanism for resolving investor-state disputes under international law (or the omission thereof), an important facet is frequently missing: their impact on commercial arbitration within India.

The opportunity beyond market access

India’s expanding network of BITs and FTAs presents an opportunity that goes beyond attracting foreign capital and opening export markets. Properly designed, these agreements can help India strengthen something every international business needs: a dispute-resolution system that is predictable, enforceable and trusted.

India already has the basic statutory architecture. The Arbitration and Conciliation Act, 1996, covers domestic arbitration, international commercial arbitration and the enforcement of foreign arbitral awards. The question now is how India’s treaty policy can reinforce that architecture. The answers vary.

In the first instance, India’s recent FTAs have generally omitted an investor-state dispute settlement (ISDS). However, given that a sizeable share of investment in India is made through contracts between foreign investors and Indian state agencies, future FTAs could better explain the rationale for this policy. For example, when the European Union-Australia FTA was negotiated, the contracting parties clarified that “the agreement does not cover the protection of



Arun Chawla

Director General of the Indian Council of Arbitration

India’s expanding treaty network can help build a stronger arbitration ecosystem

investments, which is not necessary given the level of trust in the respective legal systems of both parties”.

Taking a cue from this approach, India’s future FTAs should include provisions or preamble text that similarly clarify that the absence of an ISDS is justified by the availability of commercial arbitration remedies in India. Such provisions, alongside recent legislative reforms to strengthen India’s arbitration framework and the pro-arbitration approach of Indian courts, could help provide a middle ground between the state’s reservations about an ISDS and the desire of foreign investors to avoid litigating in Indian courts.

The second instance is where India’s BITs, which do provide for an ISDS, explicitly distinguish between the scope of treaty-based arbitration and commercial arbitration pursuant to a contract. For example, the India-Uzbekistan BIT excludes “disputes arising solely from an alleged breach of a contract” between the state and a foreign investor from the scope of an ISDS.

Such treaties also make access to ISDS conditional on foreign investors exhausting local remedies. They require foreign investors to submit their claims to the relevant domestic courts or administrative bodies of the host State for a specified period. The wording appears to exclude commercial arbitration tribunals seated in India. There does not appear to be a cogent policy reason for this exclusion. Accordingly, future BITs could clarify that foreign investors may also satisfy the exhaustion-of-local-remedies requirement by submitting the substance of their investment dispute to commercial arbitration in India.

Finally, India’s recent BITs indicate that the Government of India does not favour third-party funding in an ISDS. Since ISDS claims implicate sovereign decisions and can have a chilling effect on States’ regulatory policymaking, this approach is understandable. However, these considerations do not apply to commercial arbitration in India.

They should not be celebrating their role in a colonial project that eventually led to the “naqba” that displaced so many and uprooted them from their homeland.

“For Palestinians,” says their Ambassador to India, Abdullah Mohammed Abu Shawesh, “history is ...a tool for affirming roots and shaping the future, particularly in the face of an ongoing campaign against the Palestinian narrative led by the Zionist movement. ... It is therefore natural that we, as Palestinians, are highly sensitive to any attempt to manipulate history, as such attempts directly affect our right to exist and to determine our future.” In a letter to this writer, he sees “a clear Israeli effort to link contemporary India with the history of the establishment of Israel”, and questions India’s embrace of the “Israeli narrative”, arguing that the Indian soldiers were not heroes or valorous “martyrs” but “victims” of British colonial exploitation.

Indians, too, have their own ambivalence. Many feel pride in the courage of the soldiers but discomfort at the idea that Indian blood was shed in service of an imperial project that contributed to the dispossession of another people. This tension reflects a broader challenge in postcolonial memory: how to honour the sacrifices of those who served without endorsing the political aims of the empire they served under.

A site of contested memory

The challenge is that remembering Haifa today requires holding multiple truths at once. There is no denying that Indian soldiers fought with extraordinary courage. But they fought under colonial command, without agency over the political consequences, and their bravery had nothing to do with any Indian national ambitions. Their victory is celebrated in Israel and resented in parts of Palestine.

The battle of Haifa is a symbol of India’s global military legacy, but also a reminder of the moral ambiguities of the empire. It is a diplomatic bridge between India and Israel, but its role in India’s relations with the Palestinian people is morally ambiguous. Haifa, in other words, is many things, but it is above all a site of contested memory.

A mature historical consciousness does not demand choosing one narrative over another. It requires acknowledging the full complexity of the past: the bravery and the burden, the pride and the pain, the honour of the soldiers and the ambivalence of the outcomes. Haifa endures not because it offers a transcendent story, but because it forces us to confront the layered realities of history: that courage can serve causes not chosen by those who display it, that memory can unite and divide, and that the past can illuminate the present only when we are willing to face it in all its complexity.

Given these distinctions, India’s future BITs and FTAs should clarify that their prohibition of third-party funding in an ISDS does not, by itself, signal the impermissibility of such funding in commercial arbitration in India. This would, in turn, create room for Indian regulators to develop a coherent and comprehensive policy on third-party funding for the domestic commercial arbitration ecosystem, consistent with global best practices. Such a nuanced approach is also necessary for India to realise its ambition of becoming a global arbitration hub.

What investors look for

Ultimately, investors deciding where to invest their capital do not assess tax rates or market access alone. They also ask what happens when a relationship breaks down. A country that can answer this question convincingly has a significant economic advantage.

India’s recent BITs and FTAs already demonstrate an evolution towards more sophisticated dispute-resolution mechanisms that balance investment protection with the country’s needs. The opportunity now is to connect that treaty practice with the goal of bolstering commercial arbitration in India.

The goal should be straightforward: agreements that strive to prevent disputes, arbitration proceedings that resolve such disputes efficiently and responsibly, and courts that enforce arbitral awards predictably. From this perspective, India does not need to make every treaty an arbitration treaty. Yet, through subtle adjustments, it can make commercial arbitration an integral part of the infrastructure supporting the country’s trade and investment relationships.

If India gets that balance right, its growing treaty network can do more than open markets. It can help establish India itself as a jurisdiction in which international businesses are willing to make commitments, with the confidence that, when those commitments falter, any resulting dispute will be resolved credibly and efficiently.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Democracy in peril

Recent developments and moves by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to effect a vertical split in the Trinamool Congress in West Bengal are a cause for concern. The strategies of the BJP in Maharashtra and West Bengal are similar. The doctrine is “divide and rule”. Strong regional parties have

fallen victim to divisive tactics, with local disgruntled leaders being lured, threatened or influenced to rise up against their leadership and move to support BJP governments, through inducements and threats. A pliable Election Commission seems to play a scripted role in recognising parties,

allotting symbols and using its enormous powers to enforce poll conduct, more often selectively, in favour of the BJP. Now, these predatory moves are likely to follow against the JD(U) in Bihar, the Samajwadi Party in Uttar Pradesh and the Congress in Karnataka. These developments sound the death knell for

democracy.
S.V. Venkatakrishnan,
San Jose, California, U.S.

New Secretariat plan

M.K. Stalin, the leader of the DMK, has proposed an agitation against the Tamil Nadu government’s proposal to build a new Secretariat at Pattinapakkam, Chennai, as

it could affect fishermen. Earlier, when Ms. Jayalalithaa wanted to shift the Secretariat to Queen Mary’s College, lawyers approached the High Court and obtained a stay, which prevented the demolition of a college for women. Before taking any decision on shifting the Secretariat, there should be a debate,

given its far-reaching implications. It is also worth considering how wise it would be to locate the Secretariat along the coastline at a time of climate change.
N.G.R. Prasad,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Breakdown of civic infra in India

The breakdown of civic infrastructure is killing ordinary and unassuming citizens every day. Lives are now lost in India due to abject governance failure rather than to natural or traditional causes. Further, citizens' growing apathy towards governance failure is also concerning.

The age-old practice of blaming the Central and State governments is getting tiresome as it is clear that these incidents are fundamentally caused due to systemic failure, bureaucratic greed, absence of strict enforcement, and brazen entitlement of the general public.

Be it an illegal billboard in Mumbai that killed ordinary bystanders, or illegally constructed buildings that are constantly collapsing in Delhi, the same storyline follows – the police arrest the accused, suspend a few officials, a compensation is awarded (read: blood money) to the next of kin, and a vague promise to carry out a strict investigation is given. A few days later, it fades from public memory until the next tragedy occurs and conversations around civic responsibility and governance failure are reigned. One thing that is absolutely clear from these series of events is that administrative officials are privy to illegal activities, and it is their connivance that fuels the public's brazenness to break regulations.

Another common feature is that the accused responsible for the mishap usually has prior criminal offences registered against them. Despite this, they continue engaging in illegal activities because the message from the system is



Prachi Dutta

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loud and clear – that there is no accountability for individual actions and as long as corruption is fuelling the system, officials will turn a blind eye. Officials who fail in their responsibility of upholding civic order should be held liable. An official who clears or knowingly ignores an unauthorised structure should face the same consequences as the owners who built it. It is only then that one can work towards trying to enforce regulations.

Poor urban planning

While India's population size is an administrative hurdle that is unique to India, poor urban planning has exacerbated the problems caused by population pressure. A case in point are unauthorised colonies in Delhi that mushroom rapidly. The fact that these colonies are exempt from urban planning regulations gives building owners a free pass to build structures without any approval; a form of sanctioned impunity.

The entitlement of building owners is also significant. Be it in an upscale residential area or in an unauthorised colony in Delhi, building owners encroaching upon public land for their private use is a common occurrence in India. The reason for the brazenness is simple – no collective municipal drive has thoroughly addressed and deterred private encroachment.

One routinely reads about symbolic anti-encroachment drives; but most such drives are targeted at the marginalised groups of society who cannot retaliate. Selective enforcement is not enforcement, and in fact condones certain classes of encroachment. Civic action must target all private

encroachment with equal scrutiny in order to ensure compliance with norms.

In 2025, a fire broke out in a bar in Goa when fireworks were used indoors during a performance. The limited escape routes and crowding led to several people dying in the fire. While this particular outlet is permanently closed and the owners were arrested, what is upsetting is that consumers continue to patronise other establishments owned by the same owners.

In the U.S., established food and coffee chains have reported a slowdown in sales because of consumer boycott movements due to the political stance of these chains. If consumer boycott movements can lead to a slowdown of global conglomerates, then Indian consumers should also boycott establishments that have brazenly violated rules that have led to loss of life.

However, for an ordinary citizen who may not remember the incident, lack of access to compliance information such as publicly displayed compliance certificates in establishments and a public registry of violation norms, makes it harder for them to make an informed choice. Lack of access to this information is a governance failure, and access to it may be a step towards strengthening compliance with regulatory norms.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, establishments across India were under strict operating guidelines. Any deviation resulted in their immediate closure. The same enforcement must continue to be applied, and all buildings must be monitored to ensure compliance with guidelines.

Reiterating the basics of criminalisation

For four decades, the Uttar Pradesh Gangsters and Anti-Social Activities (Prevention) Act, 1986 dealt with gangsters and anti-social activities in the State. However, on August 20, a two-judge Bench of the Supreme Court in *Shiv Pratap Singh vs. State of U.P. and Himanshu Srivastava vs. State of U.P.* ruled: "the U.P. Act is still-born and the proceedings under it cannot survive". The reasons for arriving at this harsh conclusion were spelled out by Justice J.B. Pardiwala and Justice K. Vinod Chandran thus: "A gangster is defined under the Act and the determination of who a gangster is, for the purpose of punishment, is as prescribed in the Rules, left to the *ipse dixit* of the Executive. The creation of a crime, or to make an act or omission subject to penal consequences as an offence, is essentially a legislative function and it cannot be thrown away and left to sprout in the thicket of subordinate legislation".

This ruling centres around three inquiries – first, the need for the 'creation' of the crime by explicitly identifying the act made punishable by law; second, criminal law-making as exclusively a legislative function; and third, the desirability of excluding the executive from the rule-making and guilt-determination function.

For a society like ours which is used to 'name-calling' at will (*deshdrohi*, 'urban naxal' etc), it is very important to understand the value of clearly defining categories such as 'crime' or 'offence'. The idea of criminalisation is rooted in the principle of



B.B. Pande

Former Professor of Law, Delhi University

legality that draws inspiration from the maxims *nullum crimen sine lege* (no crime without law), *nulla poena sine lege* (no punishment without law), and the prohibition against ex-post facto legislation. Relying upon the principle of legality, Article 20(1) of the Constitution creates a right against conviction except for violation of a law in force at the time of the act charged as an offence, and against a penalty greater than what the law in force prescribed. In the context of the U.P. Act, the Supreme Court relied upon the definition of "offence" as employed by the General Clauses Act. Applying this test, the Court concluded, "The penal law under which the criminal proceeding is initiated should create an offence and the punishment should also be in accordance with whatever the law prescribes... We cannot find any offence having been created."

A function of legislature

Professor Herbert L. Packer, in his classic *The Limits of the Criminal Sanction* (1968), elaborated on the assignment of functions to diverse agencies for defining crime and punishment, observing: "This definitional role is assigned primarily and broadly to the legislature, secondarily and interstitially to the courts, and to no one else". In the U.P. Act case too, the Court expressed strong reservations against leaving matters relating to crime or punishment at the mercy of subordinate legislation. The reasoning behind this advocacy for legislative action, as against subordinate legislative action, is to ensure detailed debate and due deliberation at the stage of enacting a criminal law. Problems arise when the

opinions of the executive are accepted unquestionably in matters of categorisation and punitive action. Section 23 of the U.P. Act provides special provisions for trial, bail, and rule-making power. Chapter 3 of the Act prescribes the procedure for preparing the 'gang chart'. In this and in many earlier cases, challenges have arisen over the operation of the Rules in arriving at the decision to accord the status of 'gangster' to someone or the quantum of punishment, with it repeatedly being argued that executive authorities reach conclusions of culpability without verifiable evidence or reasoning. The Court ruled, "In the context of mere status being punished, which is determined by the administrative and police authorities by the preparation of a gang chart, nothing remains to be considered by the judicial officer but to punish him... The end result of a trial under the U.P. Act is a foregone conclusion, a statutory imprimatur to punish". The Court reinforced its stand against the *ipse dixit* of the Executive with hard-hitting reasoning: "However compelling or threatening the social menace, any penal enactment to curb that, it cannot lead to arbitrary and capricious actions against the one, alleged with the commission of an offence".

This categorical SC ruling is laudable. It has not only laid out an elaborate agenda for a reform of the Gangster Act, but has forthrightly reiterated the basics of criminalisation and the limits within which agencies are supposed to operate.

For a society like ours which is used to 'name-calling' at will (*deshdrohi*, 'urban naxal' etc), it is very important to understand the value of clearly defining categories such as 'crime' or 'offence'

The influence of Dalit voters in Uttar Pradesh

While the BSP has remained the most popular choice among Dalit voters, the BJP is steadily gaining ground particularly within the non-Jatavs

DATA POINT

Sanjay Kumar
Vibha Attrti

More than six months ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, political parties are already looking for issues that can help them mobilise voters. The Congress rally addressed by Mallikarjun Kharge at the Ramlila Ground in Haldwani, and the puja that was performed by some people afterwards, which has been described as a *shuddhikaran* (purification) puja, has emerged as one such issue that the Congress is seeking to capitalise on. Though the party knows that its Dalit support in the State is minuscule, it is trying to expand its appeal among Dalit communities.

For Uttar Pradesh, however, the larger question is not simply whether political parties will try to mobilise Dalit voters – they certainly will – but how much of the Dalit vote remains transferable, and which party or alliance can attract it in big numbers to make a difference in the 2027 Assembly election?

The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) had remained the most popular choice among the Dalit voters, though more so among Jatavs and slightly less so among non-Jatav Dalits. Over the years, a large number of Jatavs have voted for the BSP; however, some decline is visible in recent elections. When the BSP came to power in the State in the Assembly elections held in 2007, 86% of the Jatavs voted for the BSP while only 54% of non-Jatav Dalits voted for it. In the last Assembly elections held in 2022, this figure dropped to 65% among Jatavs, while its support among non-Jatav Dalits declined to 27% (Table 2 & 3). The BSP's hold on the Dalit vote has weakened over the years. On the other hand, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has been able to make noticeable inroads among

this group, though these gains are still not sizable enough.

Dalit vote patterns

The pattern becomes even more striking when one looks into the voting pattern of Jatavs and non-Jatav Dalits separately.

The support for the BJP/National Democratic Alliance (NDA) among Jatavs increased from just 3% in 2002 to about 20% in the Assembly elections held in 2022, while the BSP's support among Jatavs declined from 76% in 2002 to 65% in 2022 (Table 2). Among non-Jatav Dalits, the shift is noticeably sharper (Table 3). Here, the BJP/NDA support increased from 12% in 2002 to 40% in 2022, while the BSP's support fell from 45% to 27% over the same period.

The data clearly suggest that the weakening of the BSP is not a mere fragmentation of the Dalit vote; rather, much of the vote that has moved away from the BSP has gone to the BJP, especially among non-Jatav Dalits.

Between 2002 and 2022, support for the BJP/NDA among non-Jatav Dalits has increased by 28 percentage points, compared to a 17-point increase among Jatavs.

The weakening of the BSP's hold is also reflected in its overall decline in Uttar Pradesh. The party's vote share declined from 30.4% in 2007 to 12.8% in 2022 (Table 1). Over the same period, the BJP/NDA's vote share increased from 18.5% to 43.8%, while the Samajwadi Party (SP)/SP+ (plus means allies) also increased its vote share from 25.4% to 36.3%. The BSP's overall vote share fell sharply, but both the BJP+ and SP+ have expanded their bases.

The Congress's play

The Congress's support amongst Dalit voters is extremely low, as it is among many other communities, but the party does not want to lose any chance and sees the Ramlila Ground incident as an opportunity to bring sections of Dalit voters back into its fold. It is

important to note that the Congress has failed to secure considerable Dalit support, be it among Jatavs or non-Jatav Dalits. Its vote share has remained in the single digits among both groups, with the exception of the 2012 Assembly elections, when the Congress secured 16% of the non-Jatav Dalit vote. Even in the 2012 elections, Congress's gain among non-Jatav Dalits did not translate into a durable shift in its favour. By 2022, its support among this group had fallen back to just 4%.

While the Congress continues to make efforts to regain its Dalit support from the BSP, available data, however, suggest that Congress faces a difficult task. The weakening of the BSP has not, so far, translated into a significant recovery for the party among either Jatavs or non-Jatav Dalits.

Elections are due in early 2027, and parties will continue trying to mobilise Dalits as well as other caste communities. Only the results will indicate which party manages to successfully mobilise Dalit voters. But the data already provide an important indication – that the Dalit vote remains electorally important, and that it is no longer tied firmly to one party as it once was. The weakening of the BSP does not mean that Dalit voters have stopped having clear political preferences. Rather, the data suggest that the BJP has gained significantly from the BSP's decline, particularly among non-Jatav Dalits, while the SP has also retained a meaningful share of Dalit support. The Congress, however, has so far failed to emerge as a significant beneficiary of this shift.

Given the sizable share of Dalit voters in Uttar Pradesh, their preferences are likely to remain important to the outcome of the 2027 Assembly election. The key question is therefore not whether the Dalit vote matters, but how transferable that vote has become and whether any party can consolidate support across Jatav and non-Jatav Dalits.

Split in the share

Data for the charts were sourced from Lokniti CSDS.



Who gets the vote: Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supporters during a public meeting addressed by party chief Mayawati ahead of the Lok Sabha polls, in Moradabad, on April 15, 2024. PTI

Table 1: Performance of political parties in Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections from 2002 to 2022(%)					
	2002	2007	2012	2017	2022
BSP	23.06	30.43	25.91	22.23	12.88
BJP/NDA	23.6	18.45	15	41.35	43.82
SP/SP+	25.37	25.43	29.13	28.4	36.32
Congress/ Congress+	8.96	8.61	13.98	-	2.33

Congress currently receives only around four to five percent of the Dalit vote, but there was a time when Congress was the first and most popular choice of Dalit voters in U.P. While the party is actively trying to mobilise Dalit votes, it is yet to be seen how successful it will be

Table 2: How Jatavs voted in Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections from 2002 to 2022 (%)					
	2002	2007	2012	2017	2022
BSP	76	86	60	87	65
BJP/NDA	3	3	4	8	20
SP/SP+	2	3	13	3	9
Congress/ Congress+	4	2	5	-	1



Table 3: How non-Jatav Dalits voted in Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections from 2002 to 2022(%)					
	2002	2007	2012	2017	2022
BSP	45	54	44	44	27
BJP/NDA	12	12	7	33	40
SP/SP+	18	15	16	13	23
Congress/ Congress+	8	5	16	-	4

Note: Congress was in an alliance with SP during the 2017 Assembly elections

Sanjay Kumar is a Professor and an Election Analyst. Vibha Attrti is a Research Associate with Lokniti-CSDS. Views expressed are personal and do not reflect the views of the institution.

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 23, 1976

Apples instead of garlands

Vijayawada, September 22: A policy decision of the Andhra Pradesh Cabinet made last week that Ministers on tour should not accept garlands has come into force at once. When the Chief Minister and his colleagues were on a visit to Krishna district this week, the familiar scenes of Ministers being weighted with garlands were absent.

The Chief Minister Mr. J. Vengal Rao, and his colleagues were, however, presented with bouquets and new clothes and taken in a procession to the accompaniment of explosion of crackers. The Government would stop these also shortly, announced the Chief Minister at Nandigama.

In Vijayawada yesterday, men connected with the road transport industry and trade presented apples to Dr. D. Rama Rao, Minister for Roads and Buildings, Mr. Ch. Hanumaiah, Minister for Transport and Mr. K.P.V. Raghava Rao, General Secretary, Andhra Pradesh Congress at a reception given to them.

Looking at numerous apples placed on the table, Mr. Raghava Rao commented that the offering of so many apples also was not in tune with the spirit of the Government's decision on garlands.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 23, 1926

Broadcasting in Calcutta

Calcutta, September 23: To provide wireless entertainments equal to the standard of those in Great Britain and America is the aim of the Indian Radio Broadcasting Company which proposes to establish a broadcasting station in Calcutta. The company requires an area of five cottahs of land as site for the erection of two masts or towers and of transmitting station and further area for the construction of earth system which will consist of wires buried under ground. Negotiations are now pending for the site in Cossipore Chitpore Park which the Improvement Trust is constructing and a particular buried wire system of earthing has been proposed in order that lawns, flower beds and playing fields shall not be interfered with.

It is understood that if the scheme matures, the broadcasting station will be of similar capacity to that of London so that Bengal may enjoy a service of broadcasting more or less similar in quality to that enjoyed in western countries.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount absorbed by RBI via overnight VRRR auction

71,971 in ₹ crore. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Tuesday absorbed ₹71,971 crore from the banking system through an overnight variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auction amid a huge surplus. Liquidity in the banking system is estimated to be in surplus of around ₹4.92 lakh crore as of September 21. PTI

Foreigners detained by Delhi police for ‘drug peddling, illegal stay’

191 The Delhi Police detained 191 foreign nationals during a month-long operation aimed at identifying people allegedly residing illegally in the city and suspected of involvement in drug peddling and other unlawful activities, officials said on Tuesday. The operation, named ‘Vista 1.0’, focused on verifying the visa and immigration status of foreign nationals. PTI

Refugees who fled to Djibouti amid fighting in Yemen

10,000 The number of refugees fleeing across the Red Sea to Djibouti jumped to 10,000 amid renewed fighting in Yemen, while displacement inside Yemen could swell to over 230,000, the UN warned Tuesday. The Iran-backed Houthis seized control of Yemen’s Red Sea coastline earlier this month. AFP

Respiratory cases in regions affected by haze in Indonesia

174,694 An official from Indonesia’s Health Ministry said Tuesday that more than 170,000 respiratory cases were recorded in regions affected by haze, as the country battles to control fires that caused the toxic smog. Blazes in Borneo, Sumatra and Papua have blanketed parts of the archipelago. AFP

Percentage decline in Samsung India’s profits in FY26

36 in per cent. the profit of Samsung India Electronics declined 36 per cent to ₹7,228.10 crore for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, according to a RoC filing by the consumer electronics major. However, its revenue from operations rose slightly by 1.2 per cent to ₹1.12 lakh crore in FY26, according to data from Tofler. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Towards recognising women farmers

Maharashtra’s passage of the Women Farmers’ Empowerment Bill, granting women independent recognition as farmers irrespective of land ownership, brings into focus the structural bias against the female agricultural workforce, highlights the need for a database of women farmers and using it to ensure access to welfare schemes

ECONOMIC NOTES

Sanchit Gupta
Tanu M. Goyal

Picture a farmer. The image that comes to mind is of a man. But when one looks at who is actually farming, she is increasingly likely to be a woman. This perception-reality mismatch is caused by age-old practices of collecting data, designing policies and defining who a farmer is. It makes millions of women who work on farms, make agricultural decisions and contribute to production nearly invisible. That may, however, finally be beginning to change.

In July 2026, Maharashtra passed the Women Farmers’ Empowerment Bill, granting women independent recognition as farmers irrespective of land ownership, through a Woman Farmer Certificate. This is the first Indian State legislation to give enforceable legal form to the activity-based, land-delinked definition of ‘farmer’ that the National Policy for Farmers set out in 2007 but never operationalised. The Bill arrives nearly two decades after that policy, and 15 years after a comparable law was first proposed at the national level (a lapsed bill introduced in the Rajya Sabha in 2011). It is, in effect, the culmination of three decades of women farmers’ movements backed by civil society organisations.

State-level efforts have also sought to recognise women farmers before this. Kerala’s Kudumbashree collectives have enabled women to participate in group farming, while Odisha’s KALIA scheme has reached landless and sharecropper women. But a women farmers’ registry delinked from land records had been missing. Maharashtra’s legislation, therefore, represents a potentially important shift, from recognising the owner of agricultural land to recognising the person who actually farms. This matters because women’s participation in agriculture has risen sharply.

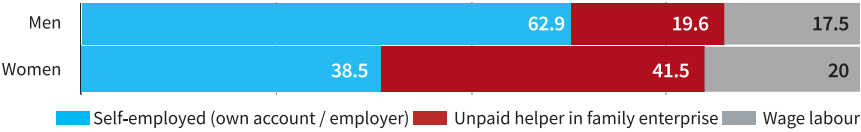
The recognition gap
In 2025, agriculture employed roughly 110 million women and 127 million men (rural, as per the PLFS, Census adjusted), bringing the sector close to gender parity. Women’s agricultural workforce has more than doubled since 2017-18, and nearly three-quarters of all rural women workers are now in agriculture, compared with less than half of men. Regrettably most women work without pay. In 2025, more than 41% of female agricultural workers were unpaid, against 20% of men (Chart 1). By contrast, nearly 63% of men were own-account workers compared with 39% of women. While women’s position has improved over time, the gap remains stark. This is where the question of recognition becomes critical, as women are increasingly farming but are not necessarily recognised as farmers.

The worker-owner dichotomy
In India, women largely work on the family lands, even though they may not own it or have their name on the land records, as patriarchal norms have meant that the land records are primarily in men’s names. Subsequently, only 14% of operational agricultural land holdings (as measured primarily through land records) are with women (according to the Agricultural

Unseen workforce

All States have women engaged in farming, but many remain unrecognised as farmers, leaving them out of databases and limiting their access to welfare schemes

Chart 1: Employment status of rural workers in agriculture and allied (% within each gender)



1 Nearly three-quarters of all rural women workers are employed in agriculture, compared with less than half of men

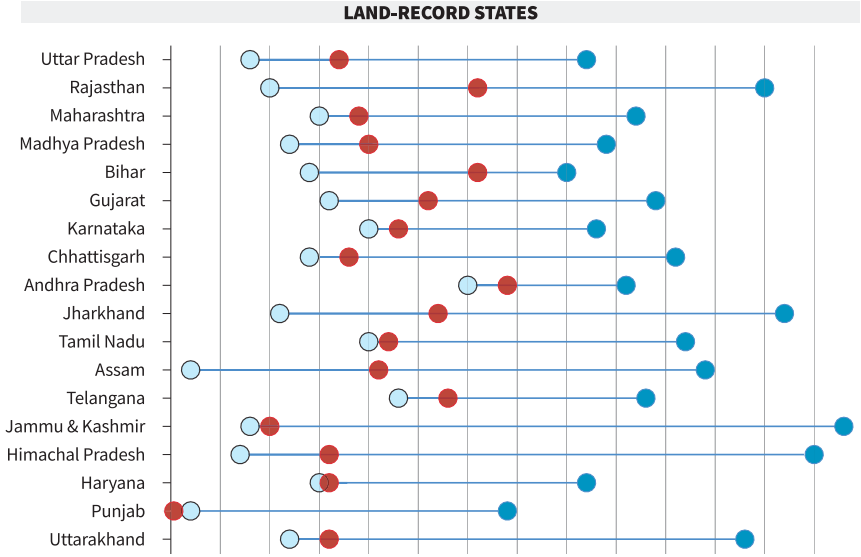


2 Women largely work on family land, though they may not own it or have their names on the land records

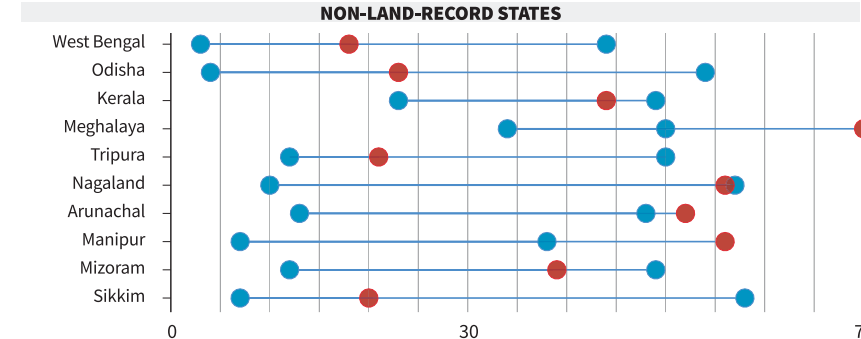
Source: Periodic Labour Force Survey 2025; rural workers aged 15+ in agriculture and allied sectors

Chart 2: Three measures for estimating the recognition gap

● Women as % of total agriculture and allied workers (2025, age 15+, usual status, rural+urban) ● Women operational holdings as % of total operational holdings (2015-16) ● Women beneficiaries as % of total PM-KISAN beneficiaries (2024, eligible)



■ PM-KISAN and operational holdings data sit 9 years apart. Where PM-KISAN’s share exceeds operational holdings share, it also reflects that the scheme counts individuals per landholding family (including successor widows), while the Census counts each holding once through land records - not necessarily translating into more land in women’s names. Punjab’s very low PM-KISAN share follows a large reduction in its beneficiary base over many successive instalments.



■ These States lacked standard land records for the Census and used sample estimates. PM-KISAN either used updated records or alternative methodology for Northeastern States among these, partly explaining the larger share of PM-KISAN women beneficiaries in them. Meghalaya’s high share reflects matrilineal inheritance, under which women are the customary landholders.

Note: States are ordered by the number of rural working women in agriculture (2025). Each dot is women’s share of a different total, in different years - of all agricultural workers, of all operational holdings, and of all scheme beneficiaries, approximating the recognition gap.

Source: Periodic Labour Force Survey 2025, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation; Agriculture Census 2015-16, Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare; PM KISAN eligible beneficiary data, 2024

Census 2015-16). The person whose name is in the records gets included in the database and receives the benefits. As a result, not only does the recognition of women agricultural workers as farmers remain ambiguous, but they are also unable to access key Central and State agricultural schemes and incentives linked to land titles (land records).

All States have a large population of women engaged in farming who are never counted as farmers. Since each State uses its land revenue records as the source of truth for administrative purposes, the structural bias against women is carried forward into scheme access and databases. This ultimately translates into women farmers being unable to access credit, subsidies, technology, extension services and

The Maharashtra Act recognises women engaged in agriculture for at least one agricultural season a year, irrespective of the nature of the land

other related opportunities. For instance, only 23% of women have been beneficiaries of the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-KISAN) scheme, which provides direct financial assistance of ₹6,000 per year to eligible landholding farmer families to support their agricultural expenses and household needs. For some States, the gap widens (See Chart 2).

Even in States where the share of women in the agriculture workforce is more than 50%, the share of women beneficiaries in most States is less than

one-third. The exceptions are revealing. Meghalaya, where women account for 70% of beneficiaries, followed by Kerala with 44% stand apart. These States have institutional or social arrangements that provide women with greater recognition or access to land and agricultural resources. In some northeastern States, customary tenure and matrilineal systems matter; in Kerala, collective farming through groups such as Kudumbashree provides an alternative route to participation and recognition.

At the other extreme are States with some of the widest gaps. In Jammu & Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh, women make up nearly two-thirds of the workforce but represent a small fraction of beneficiaries. The binding constraint, therefore, is not land itself but the identification system built on it. Where the land record is the gatekeeper, women are more likely to be filtered out; where an alternative mechanism exists, women’s access rises substantially.

Year of the Woman Farmer

While the Maharashtra legislation came after decades of advocacy, it is well timed. With the United Nations naming 2026 the International Year of the Woman Farmer, Maharashtra has taken a potentially transformative first step and paved the way for other States. The Maharashtra Act broadens the definitions of ‘agriculture’ and ‘farmer’ to recognise women residents engaged in agriculture for at least one agricultural season a year, irrespective of the nature of the land, through a ‘Woman Farmer Certificate’.

Importantly, it explicitly recognises categories like landless cultivator, landless livestock rearer, agricultural labourer, plantation labourer, and pastoralist. In principle, this creates a route through which women who do not own land can obtain an independent agricultural identity and gain access to state welfare schemes and credit. But recognition on paper is only the beginning. Implementation will require either self-registration or identification of women farmers by the Gram Sabha, including women who have no land or no land titles in their name. In both cases, this will require a robust information campaign.

This also provides for a new database of women farmers. Connecting this database with existing agricultural databases and avoiding duplication or exclusion will need to be worked out, presenting an opportunity for States to work together. A standardised system across States, for establishing common definitions for identifying women farmers, issuing certificates, and maintaining databases, would make it easier to link the identities of women farmers across schemes and administrative platforms, while avoiding multiple registrations.

But recognition must then translate into access. Linking these certificates to the Agri Stack (a digital platform developed by the Union Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare) and issuing FarmerIDs to the women is essential to integrating them into the broader digital agricultural ecosystem. However, for recognition to translate into empowerment, continuous efforts at the local level will be needed to make women farmers aware of the schemes and effectively ensure their access. (The authors work at the Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER). Views expressed are personal.)

THE GIST

▼ In July 2026, Maharashtra passed the Women Farmers’ Empowerment Bill. This is the first Indian State legislation to give enforceable legal form to the activity-based, land-delinked definition of ‘farmer’

▼ It explicitly recognises categories such as landless cultivators, landless livestock rearers, agricultural labourers, plantation labourers and pastoralists. In principle, this creates a route through which women who do not own land can obtain an independent agricultural identity and gain access to welfare schemes

▼ But recognition must then translate into access. Linking these certificates to Agri Stack and issuing Farmer IDs to women is essential to integrating them into the broader digital agricultural ecosystem

INBRIEF



PhonePe gets UAE initial nod for payment licences

Digital payments platform PhonePe said on Tuesday it received in-principle approval from the UAE central bank for two licenses covering retail payment services, card schemes, and stored value facilities. The Walmart-backed fintech firm said the approval follows initial regulatory due diligence and that it still needs final central bank sign-off before it can begin commercial operations in the Gulf state. REUTERS

India's first blue bond set for launch next week, official says

India's first maritime lender, Sagarmala Finance Corporation, plans to raise funds through the country's maiden blue bond on September 28, its top executive said. The lender aims to raise ₹6 billion (\$62.62 million), including a greenshoe option of ₹5 billion, through the sale of 10-year bonds, a provisional term sheet showed. Blue bonds are a debt instrument used to finance sustainable water and marine projects, including clean water, recycling, shipping, sustainable fishing, ocean energy and mapping. REUTERS

German Green Steel and Power IPO to open on Sept. 25

German Green Steel and Power Ltd. will hit the primary market on September 25 with a ₹304-crore initial public offering (IPO). In a public announcement, the Gujarat-based company has fixed a price band of ₹132-139 per equity share for its IPO, which is scheduled to close on September 29. The IPO comprises a fresh issue of equity shares worth up to ₹290 crore and an Offer for Sale (OFS) of 10 lakh equity shares valued at ₹13.9 crore. PTI

Centre studying plan for 4 new airports in West Bengal

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Thee Centre is assessing the viability of developing four new airports in West Bengal by reviving airstrips at Balurghat and Purulia and setting up commercial aviation facilities at the IAF bases in Kalaikunda and Hasimara, officials said.

"The Airports Authority of India (AAI) is preparing a detailed project report for the four airports and will assess whether airline services there are feasible," officials of the Ministry of Civil Aviation said.

Officials could not confirm whether the airports would be developed under the UDAN scheme, saying the plan was still at an early stage. The Centre's UDAN regional connectivity scheme (RCS) subsidises

AAI asked the State Govt. for 38.25 acre land at Kalaikunda, 38 acre at Hasimara for civil enclaves

airlines serving tier-2 and tier-3 cities and caps fares to keep tickets affordable.

Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol told the Rajya Sabha in August 2026 that there were plans to use the Kalaikunda and Hasimara IAF bases for commercial flights, but "the requisite land has not been handed over by the State Government."

Clearing hurdles

With the BJP defeating the TMC in the 2026 Assembly election and forming government in West Bengal, officials say it will now be

'Squatting' on mining assets a concern, says Mines Secretary

Senior official says some miners do not commence operations within a stipulated time-frame, such 'squatting' rests on speculative tendencies

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Certain miners holding on to their acquired blocks without commencing timely operations – or 'squatting' – is a cause for concern that the industry must look to address, Union Mines Secretary Keshav Chandra said at the 60th Annual General Meeting of the Federation of the Indian Mineral Industries (FIMI) here on Tuesday.

Separately, the senior official told mediapersons that India had kept prospects open on a return to lithium exploration in Mali. He also informed that a policy for processing of lithium and nickel was in the works.

Mr. Chandra mentioned that the government was also concerned about 'squatting' over mines.

Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of the AGM, Mr. Chandra explained that mining commences after "arduous" process of approvals, including forest and environmental clearances.

Thereafter, after the mining lease is signed, the miners are expected to commence operations within a given "substantial" time-frame. Despite that, some operations do not start, he said.

"It affects mineral



Union Mines Secretary Keshav Chandra speaking to mediapersons on the sidelines of the 60th AGM of FIMI. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

wealth [of the country]; the production gets compromised. I requested members to expedite [operationalisation] and not contravene the provisions," he said in response to a query from *The Hindu*.

In his address, Mr. Chandra said that 'squatting' would not help anybody and was centred on speculation.

"Squatting is not going to help anybody. It [squatting] is a speculation, so no activity should promote any speculation," he said, emphasising the very purpose of government reforms in the mining sectors were aimed at accelerating production and ensure the country's progress in this sector.

Mali lithium project

Mr. Chandra affirmed that India was looking "very openly" at visiting the Rus-

sian project for lithium extraction in Mali.

Russia's State Atomic Energy Corporation had approached India last year for a collaborative effort for lithium extraction in the West African country.

It was reported that the pact was kept on hold owing to the political instability in Mali. "We are looking at it very openly. We are looking at all the possibilities," he said in response to a query from *The Hindu*.

The Mines Secretary also said at the AGM that a "very substantial" scheme for domestic processing of nickel and lithium was in the works.

"For lithium and nickel, very soon we would be launching our [Mines Ministry's] scheme," he said, adding they would aid to localise the entire battery ecosystem relying on the two minerals.

SEBI settles Hindenburg-related proceedings against Adani Group entities

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has settled adjudication proceedings against the five Adani group companies, for an amount of ₹1.5 crore, according to an order released on Tuesday.

The proceedings relate to the now defunct short seller-researcher Hindenburg's allegations regarding undisclosed related party transactions (RPTs) as well as violation of disclosure and corporate governance norms.

Following this, the capital markets watchdog carried out an investigation into Hindenburg's allegations of listing regulation and equity listing agreement violations.

In the investigation, SEBI found that Adani Enterprises Ltd. (AEL) said RPTs between Adani Estates Private Limited, a subsidiary of AEL and Vakoder Investment Ltd., a related party of AEL, were not disclosed in the Annual Report for FY2013.

In addition to this, the company had violated other laws and rules under the Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirement, (LODR) and clauses in listing agreement.

The other four companies, Adani Total Gas Ltd., AWL Agri-Business Ltd., Adani Green Energy Ltd. and Adani Energy Solutions Ltd. too were found

violating LODR regulations, sections under SEBI Act and NSE, BSE bye-laws.

ATGL, AABL, and AGEL violated LODR sections pertaining to non-peer-review of audit reports. AESL violated sections under the NSE and BSE by-laws in addition to clauses under its listing agreement.

Show-cause notice

SEBI sent a show-cause notice to the five companies asking them to explain why an inquiry should not be held and penalties imposed for the alleged violations. Pending adjudication proceedings, the five companies proposed to settle with the regulator without admitting or denying the allegations.

Based on the settlement terms recommended by SEBI's High Powered Advisory Committee, AEL paid ₹76.05 lakh, AGEL ₹45.50 lakh and the rest of the companies paid ₹9.75 lakh each.

"In view of the acceptance of the settlement terms and the receipt of settlement amount by SEBI, the instant adjudication proceedings initiated against the Applicants vide SCN dated February 15, 2024 is disposed of in terms of section 15JB of the SEBI Act and section 23JA of the SCRA read with regulation 23(1) of the Settlement Regulations on the basis of the settlement terms," SEBI said in the settlement order.



The VRRR auction was held for ₹75,000 crore.

RBI absorbs ₹71,971 crore liquidity from banks

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

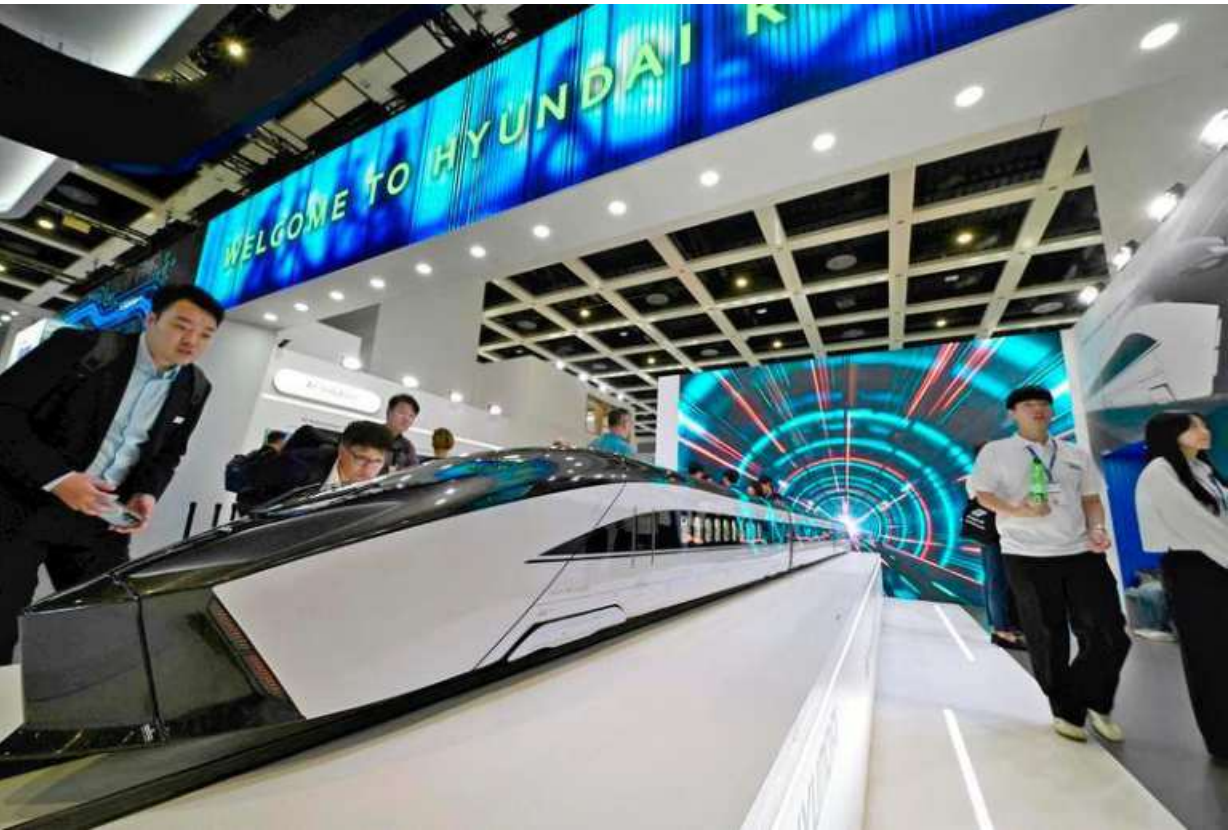
The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has absorbed ₹71,971 crore liquidity from the banking system through over night Variable Reverse Repo Rate (VRRR) auction, according to a notification released on Tuesday.

VRRR is the rate at which banks park their funds with the RBI. It is a tool that central banks use to suck liquidity.

The VRRR auction was held for ₹75,000 crore and offers were received for 96% of the amount for a rate of 5.24%. The overnight facility had a tenor of one day.

Keeping in mind that excess liquidity can be inflationary, the RBI has been absorbing excess liquidity from the system, especially after an overwhelming response from the special deposit scheme for NRIs filling up RBI's coffers with \$133 billion. The VRRR operation also intends to bring the overnight call money rate in sync with the repo rate, ahead of a potential rate hike cycle.

Switching tracks



Train to the future: A mockup of Hyundai's next generation high speed train is on display at the InnoTrans International Trade Fair for Transport Technology on Tuesday in Berlin. From September 22 to 25, 2026, around 600 companies from the Railway Infrastructure and Tunnel Construction sectors will present their latest products and services, at the fair. AFP

Steel prices at 4-year high; trend to stay in H2: report

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Domestic steel prices have touched a four-year high on costlier raw materials, especially coking coal, coupled with a rise in post-monsoon demand, according to market research company BigMint.

The trend is expected to continue over the remaining quarters of the ongoing fiscal year, BigMint said in a report.

Hot rolled coil (HRC) and CRC – two of the most common types of flat steel products used globally – are trading at ₹64,000 per tonne and ₹75,000 a tonne, respectively.

Such levels were last seen in June 2022, BigMint data showed.

Smartphone screen protectors under BIS

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Centre has mandated compulsory Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) certification for smartphone screen protectors, requiring entities to secure regulatory approval before selling such products in India.

The move is expected to curb sales of low-quality smartphone screen protectors and help firms like Optemus Infracom, which started production in India. Mobile device makers' body ICEA chairman Pan-kaj Mohindroo said mandatory BIS certification from April 1, 2027, will protect consumers from sub-



Market for screen protectors is estimated at ₹20,000 crore.

standard products while creating a level playing field for local manufacturers and global firms. The local market for tempered glass screen protectors is estimated at 400 million pieces with a retail value of ₹20,000 crore in 2025.

SoftBank-backed AceVector's ₹420-cr. IPO to open on Sept. 25

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

SoftBank-backed digital commerce ecosystem AceVector Ltd. on Tuesday fixed a price band of ₹30-32 per equity share for its ₹420-crore upcoming initial public offering (IPO).

The IPO will open for public subscription on September 25 and close on September 29, while bidding by anchor investors will take place on September 24, according to a public announcement.

The IPO comprises a fresh issue of equity shares worth ₹287 crore and an Offer-for-Sale (OFS) of 4.16 crore shares valued at ₹133

crore by existing shareholders. At the upper end of the price band, the issue size is around ₹420 crore.

Existing investors, including SoftBank, Nexus Venture Partners and Foxconn, among others, will sell a small part of their shareholding through the OFS. Co-founders Kunal Bahl and Rohit Bansal, who together hold a 33.99% stake in AceVector individually and through their jointly owned entity B2 Professional Services LLP, are not selling any shares in the IPO.

AceVector has trimmed the IPO size from the earlier plan of a ₹300-crore fresh issue and an OFS of

6.38 crore equity shares.

AceVector operates an asset-light digital commerce ecosystem comprising Snapdeal, a value-focused lifestyle e-commerce marketplace; Unicommerce, an e-commerce enablement SaaS platform; and Stellaro Brands, an omnichannel consumer brands retailing business.

Unicommerce, the e-commerce enablement SaaS platform, got listed on the stock exchanges in 2024, with its IPO subscribed over 168 times.

In FY26, AceVector reported operating revenue of ₹510.38 crore, a 29% increase from ₹395.02 crore in FY25.

Orient Cables to raise ₹552 cr. through IPO

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Network cables and optical fibre manufacturer Orient Cables India Ltd. is set to raise ₹552 crore through an initial public offering (IPO).

The offer consists of a fresh issue of ₹320 crore and current owners diluting ₹232 crore of their stake.

The company has fixed a price band of ₹258-₹272 a piece and the shares can be bought in lots of 55 shares and the multiples thereof.

The IPO opens for subscription on September 25 and closes on September 29, 2026.

Samsung India net slips as mobiles lag

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Samsung India Electronics profit declined 36% to ₹7,228.10 crore for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, according to a RoC filing by the consumer electronics major.

However, revenue from operations rose 1.2% to ₹1.12 lakh crore in FY26, as per financial data accessed through business intelligence platform Tofler.

Samsung India Electronics gets its major contribution to the topline from the mobile phone business.

Revenue from the Home Appliances (HA) business increased 3.52% to



Revenue from operations rose 1.2% to ₹1.12 lakh cr. in FY26.

₹12,240.60 crore. Samsung is focusing on strengthening its television and appliances business, where it competes with players such as LG, Whirlpool, Haier and Voltas, as part of its strategy to diversify revenue streams

CM
YK



Lingering memory: A display of the book by Princess Diana's brother at a store in London. REUTERS

Claims in memoir by Diana's brother cause royal ruckus

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Charles Spencer's book about his late sister, Princess Diana, packed with explosive revelations was published on Tuesday, after searing extracts prompted a rare and sharp rebuttal from King Charles III.

Almost three decades after Diana was killed in a car crash in Paris in 1997, people remain fascinated by her life and tragic death.

Swan Song: Diana, My Sister, a memoir written by Diana's younger brother, has been published by Penguin and translated into 12 languages.

But extracts serialised in the British tabloid the *Daily Mail* over the past few days have triggered sensational headlines.

Mr. Spencer has said he wrote the book to "speak on Diana's behalf" and correct "untruths that have become accepted over time".

"Diana would be cheering from the rafters at this book, I have no doubt about that," he told the *Mail* on Sunday.

Published excerpts claimed her ex-husband Charles, then Prince of Wales, and now the king, told Spencer in a phone call after Diana's death: "Rest assured, we'll forget her soon enough."

Her death at the age of 36 sparked an outpouring of grief in Britain for the woman dubbed "the people's princess". And it triggered accusations that the then monarch, Queen Elizabeth II, failed to respond with empathy and understanding.

Mr. Spencer claimed Mr. Charles had "sounded giddily elated, like a lottery winner" at the news of Diana's demise.

A Buckingham Palace spokesperson issued a rare reaction from the 77-year-old king, saying: "His Majesty is mindful that the pain of fraternal grief can cloud reason, affect judgment and colour memory in ways others do not recognise, even many years after such a loss."

NEWS ANALYSIS

Joan Sony Cherian

On September 20, the far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) won a major mandate in yet another State election in Germany, this time in the coastal province of Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania, also a former East Germany region. It won 38.2% of votes. This is the second major victory for the AfD after winning the State elections in Saxony-Anhalt earlier this month.

However, the mandate in both States is not enough for the AfD to form a government on its own. The strategy of 'Brand-mauer' or firewall against the AfD, adopted by major political parties to keep the far-right party out of power, makes the question of a coalition government very tentative.

The biggest upset, however, was the crash of Chancellor Friedrich Merz's Christian Democratic Union (CDU) which failed to win the threshold 5% of vote share, which makes it ineligible to be a part of the representative body of the Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania province. It will not even have one seat in the regional Parliament – the first such instance in more than 70 years of modern German history.

Such a mandate has come as a big blow to

Chancellor Merz who was already "deeply shocked" at the results in Saxony-Anhalt. He described his party's loss in Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania a "disaster".

A jubilant AfD which had warned Mr. Merz that "his time was running out" in the Bundestag [Parliament's lower house], earlier this month did not mince words in attacking the premier. Party co-leader Tino Chrupalla said that he expected Mr. Merz to resign now. "That would truly be a relief for this country," he said.

The CDU also faced a setback in the election in Berlin, with the leftist Die Linke emerging as the largest party in the capital with 25.7% of the vote share, followed by the CDU at 18.8%.

When Mr. Merz first took up the reins of government last year following the federal elections, his win was overshadowed by the staggering rise of the AfD which stood in second place after the CDU and its Bavarian sister-party, the Christian Social Union (CSU), with almost 20% of the vote share. At the time, Mr. Merz had remarked that the AfD was "a real alarm bell for political parties". He had promised to counter the rise of the far-right party, and alleviate concerns regarding high energy bills, rising inflation, and immigration.

However, the German public is of the opinion that Mr. Merz has failed to



Holding firm: CDU leader Friedrich Merz has vowed to keep his ruling coalition together for Germany's 'democratic future'. AFP

make good on his promises.

National borrowing

Prior to the elections, Mr. Merz had said that he wouldn't increase national borrowing by breaking Germany's debt brake rule. Implemented after the 2008 global economic crisis, the debt brake places strict limits on how much federal and State governments can borrow; the federal government is required to limit annual borrowing to 0.35% of GDP. However, considering the shrinking of the German economy for two consecutive years in a row, in 2023 and 2024, the government felt the need to end years of economic slowdown.

In March 2025, the government of Chancellor Merz introduced a major

debt package, wherein via a Constitutional amendment, Mr. Merz pushed through an exemption to allow unlimited borrowing for defence and security purposes exceeding 1% of GDP.

This was particularly relevant as Germany is one of the biggest supporters of Ukraine in the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war. Its suspension of energy deals with Russia and the policy of gradually phasing out energy dependence on Moscow has hit the economy hard, especially low-income households, as energy bills have mounted, particularly during winters.

Along with easing the debt brake, a special fund of 500 billion euros for infrastructure spending was also approved. Further, over the course of his term,

the Merz-led government has gone on to lower some of the energy costs, and has introduced tax and health reforms. Basic allowance, child allowance and child benefits have also been increased. The government also announced that it will set up a house-building association to support social house-building and large-scale, industrialised constructions.

However, these policies, while largely welcomed, take time to show up within the economy.

Moreover, major structural reforms within the collapsing pension scheme have led to pushback against the government among the public as well as allies.

The government aims to raise the retirement age to 70 in line with higher life expectancy; Germany is one of the countries which has a rapidly ageing population with higher life expectancies. Moreover, a popular provision within the pension system which allows people who have regularly paid pension contributions for 45 years to retire early without any financial liability is potentially being scrapped.

These reforms are deeply unpopular, and has led to criticism, especially from its coalition partner, the Social Democratic Party (SPD), revealing internal fissures within an already precarious coalition. However, Mr. Merz insisted that Germany has long faced the problem that

"fewer and fewer contributors have to finance pensions for more and more retirees," adding that "doing nothing is not an option."

Mr. Merz has also adopted a more hardline position when it comes to rules and controls around immigration and asylum. Even before assuming power, he had announced a 'de facto entry ban' – a strict rejection of entry to all undocumented migrants and asylum seekers. Moreover, in July 2025, he suspended family reunification for beneficiaries of subsidiary protection for an initial period of two years. Last year, the federal government also rescinded the fast-track citizenship programme, which let "well-integrated" migrants gain citizenship in three years instead of five.

These moves are seen as the government's strategy to appease voters who are swayed by the AfD's anti-immigrant rhetoric.

Low approval ratings

In the September 2026 ARD-Deutschlandtend survey, Mr. Merz's approval rating came down to an all-time low of just 13%, and calls for his resignation have started gaining ground.

However, Mr. Merz has insisted that the election result cannot be linked to merely his popularity. He has stated that he will keep his ruling coalition together for the sake of his country's "democratic future".

Kamala Harris to hit campaign trail for El-Sayed in key Michigan Senate race

Associated Press
DETROIT

Former U.S. Vice-President Kamala Harris will campaign on Tuesday in Michigan in an effort to rally Democratic voters behind progressive Senate candidate Abdul El-Sayed in the swing State of Michigan that will help determine control of the Senate.

Ms. Harris, the first Black person to serve as Vice-President, is appearing at events in Detroit aimed at building support among Black voters. She will attend a meeting on Black maternal health with Mr. El-Sayed and appear separately at an event hosted by the Detroit chapter of the NAACP, according to her spokesperson.

Her visit comes at a pi-



Main man: Democratic candidate Abdul El-Sayed answers question during a town hall event in Waterford, Michigan. AFP

votal time in the closely watched Senate race between Mr. El-Sayed and Republican Mike Rogers, a former Congressman. If Democrats hold Michigan's Senate seat, they would still need to win four more currently held by the Republican Party, if they are to win control of the 100-

member chamber in November.

If Mr. Rogers wins, their challenge would be even greater.

Mr. Rogers has been campaigning in Detroit, a predominantly Black city where his campaign is optimistic he can pick up support from voters hesitant

to support Mr. El-Sayed. Voters in Wayne County, home to Detroit, supported Rep. Haley Stevens over Mr. El-Sayed in the August Democratic primary, favouring the more establishment-aligned Democrat who worked in President Barack Obama's administration.

The race is also seen as a referendum on the viability of a progressive platform on a national level. Mr. El-Sayed is running to the left of the Democratic Party establishment, including advocating for universal healthcare and opposing U.S. arms sales to Israel.

Ms. Harris' visit to Michigan also comes as questions swirl about her intentions to run for President in 2028.

Submerged suburbs



Heavy rain triggered by Typhoon Dujan flooded the Sakura locality on Tuesday in Japan's Chiba Prefecture. At least four people died, and about 45,000 homes near Tokyo were left without power, according to public broadcaster NHK. REUTERS

EU nations in showdown over Russian oligarch sanctions as deadline nears

Agence France-Presse
BRUSSELS

EU countries on Tuesday resumed their scramble for an agreement on prolonging sanctions on Russia, after Latvia held up a deal to take two oligarchs off the blacklist.

The 27-nation bloc had looked set to remove asset freezes and visa bans from Russian businessmen Alisher Usmanov and Mikhail Fridman after demands from France, Luxembourg and Slovakia.

The move – slammed by Kyiv – was part of a compromise to extend sanctions on almost 3,000 other individuals and companies over the Ukraine war for three more

years, before a deadline that could see them lapse at 22:00 GMT Tuesday. But that agreement hit an obstacle at the finishing line when Latvia lodged a last-ditch objection late on Monday.

"The Latvian government's stance has been unwavering. EU sanctions against Russia must be strengthened, not weakened," Foreign Minister Baiba Braze wrote online.

EU diplomats have been haggling for days over a way forward after France joined Slovakia in demanding Russian-Uzbek billionaire Usmanov to be removed from the blacklist.

Luxembourg then seized upon the demand by Paris to insist that if



Russian businessmen Alisher Usmanov (left) and Mikhail Fridman were added to the sanctions list over allegations that their businesses provided significant revenues to Kremlin's war efforts. REUTERS, AFP



sanctions were lifted on Mr. Usmanov, then they should be lifted for Mr. Fridman as well.

Officials in Paris have cited "national security" concerns for their request on Mr. Usmanov, but refused publicly to give de-

tails. A senior diplomat in Brussels said that Paris explained the demand was linked to a potential prisoner release deal involving French nationals held in Azerbaijan.

Luxembourg has pushed for Mr. Fridman to

be removed. Diplomats said the move comes as he is suing the country for \$17 billion for freezing his assets under EU sanctions.

'Dangerous precedent'

The demand from France in particular has riled oth-

er EU member states who argue that removing people for political reasons sets a dangerous precedent.

"It really sends the signal that you can blackmail your way to delisting," said one EU diplomat talking on condition of anonymity. "It's shocking that France is the one blocking it all."

EU diplomats insist there is widespread agreement that the bloc's sanctions should not be allowed to lapse – and a temporary extension could be agreed if no deal is reached on Tuesday.

But the Kremlin seized on the EU's standoff to demand that the EU lift sanctions on "all Russian businessmen".

Ukraine has reacted furiously to the prospect of the EU removing sanctions on the two prominent Russian businessmen seen as close to the Kremlin.

"Delisting is unacceptable and would send the wrong signal to Moscow at a time when pressure needs to increase," Ukraine's Foreign Minister Andriy Sybiga wrote online.

EU top diplomat Kaja Kallas urged the bloc's member states on Monday to maintain the sanctions imposed on Moscow.

"Sanctions are a core pillar of our response to Russia's war", she said.

As an offering to those opposed to the delisting move, the compromise

deal on offer in Brussels would see the sanctions remain in place for the next three years – as opposed to the previous extensions of six months each.

The EU's sanctions blacklist includes key figures such as Russian President Vladimir Putin and Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov.

Metals tycoon Usmanov and banking magnate Fridman are among dozens of Russian businessmen suing the EU over the sanctions.

Both were added to the sanctions list shortly after Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 over allegations that their businesses provided significant revenues to the Kremlin.

NEXT TARGET

‘Have to keep playing good cricket and look to win an Olympic medal’



R.V. MOORTHY

Smriti Mandhana was measured in her reaction, her ambitions clearly much bigger than continental domination. “We have to keep playing good cricket against better opposition. We can’t dwell on this win a lot, we have to see what we can do for the next one half to two years to get in the best place to win an Olympic medal”.

ELATED

I was all around... jumping, roaming and talking: Shreyanka



R.V. MOORTHY

It’s very hard when you have back-to-back injuries. If you stay positive and keep telling you can do it, anything is possible. When I was out there, I was all around jumping, roaming, and talking. It’s my first time holding a gold medal... I’m really grateful. I’m just happy to be back on the field — India’s Shreyanka Patil.

SAILING THROUGH

Jugraj, Abhishek and Dilpreet ‘trick as India hammers Lanka



X@AHF

The Indian men’s hockey team routed Sri Lanka 16-1 in its second Pool A match at the Asian Games on Tuesday. Jugraj Singh slammed four goals, while Abhishek and Dilpreet netted three each. Harmanpreet Singh struck twice while Mandeep Singh, Sukhjeet Singh, Manpreet Singh and Vivek Sagar Prasad also scored.

FANTASTIC RUN

Roshibina ensures a hat-trick of medals after entering wushu semis



FILE PHOTO

Roshibina Devi Naorem on Tuesday assured herself of a third successive Asian Games medal as she entered the semifinals of the women’s 60kg category in wushu. Roshibina was declared the winner on point difference over Macau’s Chu Man Sin in the last-eight stage at the Aichi Prefectural Martial Arts Hall.

Women in Blue retain gold in emphatic fashion

Smriti and Shafali provide the perfect launchpad with a scintillating 99-run opening stand; Richa’s cameo powers India to a daunting total before the spin quartet blows away the Lankans

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The Indian National anthem played for the first time at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games on Tuesday.

A blistering opening partnership followed by a cracking innings and spin choke-hold ensured the country its first gold at the Games.

Harmanpreet Kaur’s women retained their title in commanding fashion with a 147-run victory against Sri Lanka in the final at the Korogi Athletics Park in Nisshin.

Chasing a massive 217-run target, Sri Lanka folded up for 69 in 15.4 overs, stumbling early on and never finding their footing as Deepti Sharma and Co. didn’t allow any breathing space to the Sri Lankan batters on a small ground.

The damage with the ball was initiated, as with the bat, by Shafali Verma who sent back Imesha Dulani and Hasini Perera in consecutive overs to reduce the Islanders to 30 for two inside five overs. She didn’t bowl again but the collapse had begun and when Sri Lanka skipper Chamari Athapaththu was caught by Bharti Fulmali at long-off off Deepti, with the scoreboard reading 43 for three, it was all but over.

Chamari was the top-scorer for Lanka with 29 (21b, 5x4), one of only



Undisputed champions: The Indian women asserted their class at the continental extravaganza with a thumping 147-run win in the final. R.V. MOORTHY

three batters to reach double digits in a line-up that had three ducks. Deepti scalped three while Shreyanka Patil and Shree Charani got two wickets each as Sri Lanka ended with yet another silver from the continental showpiece after the last edition

in Hangzhou.

Earlier, having elected to bat, the Indians continued in the same vein as in the Asia Cup final nine days ago. Shafali (48, 29b, 3x4, 3x6) and Smriti Mandhana (79, 45b, 5x4, 7x6) were in imperious form. The two added 99 in the first 10 ov-

ers, scoring at over 150 strike rate each. Shafali, trying to go for a reverse sweep, failed to clear the infield, and missed out on a half-century.

Richa Ghosh’s unbeaten 22-ball 49 (6x4, 3x6) was the icing on the cake and propelled the total beyond

200 after Harmanpreet fell for 19. Smriti’s sublime but equally destructive knock was the foundation of India’s daunting 216 for three.

In the morning, Pakistan captain Fatima Sana’s 30-ball 45 and Umm-e-Hani’s three for 10 helped the team clinch the bronze

with a 31-run victory against Bangladesh in the playoff.

The scores (final): India 216/3 in 20 overs (Shafali 48, Smriti 79, Richa 49 n.o.) bt Sri Lanka 69 in 15.4 overs (Chamari 29, Shafali 2/3, Deepti 3/6, Shreyanka 2/9, Shree Charani 2/13).

Toss: India.

‘We will have this gold medal with us forever’

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Harmanpreet Kaur has done what no one else can claim to have done, or may do for a while – be the captain of an Asian Games-winning cricket team twice in a row. And she has the medals to prove it.

Firm favourite to defend its title at the Korogi Athletics Park even before the team landed in Tokyo, and coming after the high of clinching the Asia Cup, the gulf between the Women in Blue and the rest was far too wide.

“As cricketers, we always wanted to be a part of the Asian Games or Commonwealth Games or Olympics, because otherwise we only play cricket tournaments. We did not

know the value of what a medal actually means.

“We are lucky to have done it twice now because the cricketers before us did not have this. Now we can also frame two medals back home because when we win a trophy, it feels good but it goes to the BCCI office. This is something we will have with us forever... this is ours,” Harmanpreet said on Tuesday.

That the team’s gold was also the first for India at the ongoing Games only made it extra special.

“Our aim was to win gold and see the national flag high... [we] talked about the national anthem playing. But we didn’t know we would be the first to experience it here. I am sure that we have opened the golden gates”.



Joy! Harmanpreet added another feather to her cap. R.V. MOORTHY

Shooters Elavenil and Parth wilt under pressure of finals

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

India’s wait for a shooting gold at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games continued on Tuesday, as the country went medal-less on the third day of competition at the Aichi General Shooting Range, with Elavenil Valarivan and Parth Mane finishing fourth in the 10m Air Rifle mixed team event.

Having finished strongly in second place behind China in qualifying, Elavenil and Parth were expected to get India another



Elavenil, PTI

shooting medal, but pressure got the better of the young shooters, who bowed out with a total of 376.3 after 18 shots each.

Low scores of 103.6,

104.3 and 104.4 in the first three series pulled the Indians down, despite a superb showing in the fourth series that saw them shoot the highest total of 64.

China, meanwhile, set a new World Record with a score of 507.1 to add another gold to its kitty while Korea took silver (502.9) and host Japan bronze (439.7).

The Chinese pair of Sheng Lihao and Wang Zi-fei had already set a new qualifying World Record with a total of 638.9, more than four points ahead of India with 634.6.

SNAPSHOTS

Pranati in vault finals
Pranati Nayak qualified for the Asian Games vault finals in the artistic gymnastics event on Tuesday. She was seventh among 19 gymnasts to have made the final, which will be held on Thursday.

Wrestler Deepak may travel to Japan
Greco-Roman wrestler Deepak (67kg), who was removed from the Asian Games-bound Indian squad after testing positive for banned substance Clomifene, may travel to Japan after getting a favourable court order. Taking into account that Deepak was not provisionally suspended for the adverse analytical finding reported by the National Anti-Doping Agency, the Delhi HC on Tuesday directed relevant authorities, including the Government, to “consider” Deepak’s name and give “permissible relief” as per existing policy within three days.

The wrestling squad is set to leave for Japan on Saturday. The court made it clear that it passed the order solely on the basis of Deepak’s petition.

Indian men shuttlers assured of a medal



First blood: Lakshya bounced back to win the opening match against Naraoka. REUTERS

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The Indian badminton teams had a mixed day at the Asian Games with the men assuring themselves of a medal after winning 3-0 against host Japan in the quarterfinal while the women went down 1-3 to the home team at the Ichinomiya City Municipal Gymnasium on Tuesday.

It’s the first time in 40 years that the men’s team has won back-to-back medals at the Asian Games.

Women exit
The women, however, continue to wait for their first medal since the bronze in 2014.

Lakshya Sen came back

from a game down to win the opening match against Kodai Naraoka 11-21, 21-15, 21-19 to set the tone.

Lakshya trailed 13-19 before reeling off eight straight points to take the match and put India ahead 1-0.

Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty then overcame Hoki Takuro and Yugo Kobayashi 21-18, 24-22 to make it 2-0 before Ayush Shetty sealed the tie with a comprehensive 21-10, 21-19 to ensure back-to-back podium finish for the Indian men.

The women, however, were unable to find their rhythm. P.V. Sindhu, who started the proceedings, got off to a good start against World No. 3 Akane

THE INDIA SHOW		
▼ <i>A look at some Indian performances on Tuesday:</i>		
Badminton: Quarterfinals: Men’s team: bt Japan 3-0; Women’s team: lost to Japan 1-3.		
Boxing: Round-of-32: Women’s 51kg: Sakshi bt Villegas (Phi); Men’s 55kg: Jadumani bt Bahadur (Nep).		
Cricket: Women’s final: bt Sri Lanka by 147 runs.		
Gymnastics: Women’s vault (qualification): Pranati (seventh, enters final).		
Hockey: Men (Pool A): bt Sri Lanka 16-1.		
Kabaddi: Men (Group A): bt South Korea 63-31.		
Karate: Men’s kumite -84kg bronze medal bout: Chetan lost to Chung (Tpe) on Senshu after the contest ended 1-1.		
Shooting: 10m air rifle mixed team qualification: Elavenil & Parth (fourth); Skeet individual qualification (day 2): Men: Anantjeet (tied for top spot with three others), Mairaj (tied for 22nd with two others), Bhavtegh (35th); Women: Raiza (fifth), Parinaaz (tied for ninth with another shooter), Maheshwari (tied for 15th with another shooter).		
Swimming: Men: 1500m freestyle final: Aryan (12th overall); 4x100m medley relay final: Eighth.		
Table tennis: Round-of-16: Women’s team: bt Thailand 3-2; Men’s team: lost to South Korea 0-3.		
Wushu: Women: Nanquan & Nandao final: Langlontombi (ninth overall); Sanda 60kg quarterfinal: Roshibina bt Sin (Mac).		

INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY	
▼ <i>A look at some Indian players/teams who will compete on Wednesday (all times IST):</i>	
Badminton: Men’s team (semifinal): vs. China, 11.30 a.m..	individual final, 11 a.m.; Men: Skeet individual qualification and team final (day 3): Anantjeet, Mairaj, Bhavtegh (6.30 a.m.); individual final, 12.30 p.m.
Boxing: Men (from 8.30 a.m.): 80kg (round-of-16): Ankush vs. Hamsa (Brn).	Squash: Round-of-32: Men: Abhay vs. Arkarahirunya (Tha), 10.30 a.m.; Veer vs. Wakeel (SL), noon; Women: Tanvi vs. Dami (Kor), 11.15 a.m.
Equestrian: Eventing (Fouaad, Arjan, Ashish): Individual and team cross country, 6.30 a.m.	Swimming: Heats (from 6.30 a.m.): Men: 100m butterfly (Benedicton, Sajan); 200m freestyle (Vedaant, Aneesh); final (from 1.30 p.m.).
Fencing: Women’s foil individual (Mina, Ashitha), 6.30 a.m. onwards; Men’s sabre individual (Gisho, Karan), 8.15 a.m. onwards.	Table tennis: Mixed doubles (round-of-32): Harmeet & Yashaswini vs. Ismail & Fathimath (Mdv), 6.30 a.m.; Manush & Diya vs. Chanul & Swarna (SL), 7.10 a.m.; Round-of-16, 10.15 a.m. onwards.
Hockey: Women (Pool B): vs. Thailand, 11.30 a.m.	Weightlifting: Women: 49kg final: Mirabai (10 a.m.); 53kg final: Gyaneshwari (1.30 p.m.).
Kabaddi: Women (Group A): vs. Iran, 8.30 a.m.; Men (Group A): vs. Bangladesh, 9.45 a.m.	Wushu: Women’s sanda 60kg semifinal: Roshibina vs. Thania (Ina), 3 p.m.
Shooting: Women: 10m air pistol individual qualification and team final (Manu, Esha, Suruchi), 6.15 a.m.; individual final, 9 a.m.; Skeet individual qualification and team final (day 3): Parinaaz, Raiza, Maheshwari (6.30 a.m.);	

Yamaguchi but was unable to sustain the momentum, losing 23-21, 18-21, 6-21.

Unnati Hooda couldn’t find a way past 2022 World Junior champion Tomoka Miyazaki to lose 16-21, 18-21.

Recent World Championships bronze medalists Treesa Jolly and Gaya-

tri Gopichand gave some hope with a 21-17, 21-16 win against the world No.3 pair of Yuki Fukushima and Mayu Matsumoto.

But former World champion Nozomi Okuhara outplayed Tanvi Sharma 21-12, 21-10 in just 18 minutes to wrap up the tie.

INBRIEF



Yugan wins junior men's trap event at ISSF Junior WC

Yugan Sakthivel Muthukumar won gold in the junior men's trap event at the ISSF Junior World Cup held in Porpetto, Italy, recently. The 15-year-old from Tamil Nadu finished with 27 hits out of 30 to finish on top of the podium.



Hadjar to be back for Red Bull at Azerbaijan Grand Prix

Isack Hadjar will be back driving for Red Bull at this week's Azerbaijan Grand Prix after a "successful recovery" from the wrist injury which kept him out of three Formula One races, the team said on Tuesday. Hadjar injured his wrist during F1's mid-season break, reportedly during a boxing workout, and was sidelined with a splint on his arm as he recovered.

Real Madrid captain Valverde sidelined with ankle injury

Real Madrid captain Federico Valverde suffered an ankle injury in his team's weekend derby loss to Atletico Madrid. The Uruguay midfielder was hurt by a tackle from Atletico's Lee Kang-in, which Real has insisted should have resulted in a sending off for the South Korean. According to the Spanish press, Valverde will be sidelined for several weeks and will miss Uruguay's upcoming friendlies against Japan, South Korea and India.



Injured Rashid ruled out of ODIs against Sri Lanka

Veteran leg-spinner Adil Rashid has been ruled out of England's One-Day International series against Sri Lanka. The 38-year-old sustained an injury to his right, bowling, hand while fielding at Old Trafford on Saturday as England completed a 3-0 T20I whitewash. After undergoing a scan on Monday, the ECB confirmed Rashid would also be absent from Thursday's second ODI at Headingley and Sunday's final game at the Oval.

LIVE TELECAST

Asian Games: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Thursday)

India survives a mighty scare against Japan

Axar holds his nerve at the crunch as the World champion edge the minnow in a five-over shootout; umpire Thurgate reverses a wide call amid mounting pressure in the final over

CRICKET

Press Trust of India
SANO

Seasoned spinner Axar Patel choked the inexperienced Japanese batters just in time as India flirted with danger before winning the rain-curtailed one-off T20 International by a mere two runs here on Tuesday.

With the match being reduced to five overs-a-side due to inclement weather and moisture on the surface offering more than expected turn, the apparent gulf in talent and experience was seemingly bridged as India managed only 32 for four in five overs. The Word champion could hit just a couple of fours.

In the end, the sizeable expat turnout gave a standing ovation to the Japanese team whose players came up to click selfies and get their jerseys signed by some of the biggest stars of world cricket.

Jaspriit Bumrah was much in demand for autographs and photographs although he did not play. One of the Japanese players got a signed India jersey from Abhishek Sharma while skipper Shreyas Iyer also had some words of encouragement for the



Vital cameo: Shreyas' 12-ball 16 won the Indian skipper the Player-of-the-Match award. AFP

home team players.

"See I always keep saying five overs game, it can go anywhere. The attitude shown by the Japanese team was impeccable. I'm sure they are on the right track. For us, it was a great practice (ahead of the Asian Games)," Shreyas said.

While defending the target, India looked in trouble when Ravi Bishnoi went for 10 runs in the third over and Washington Sundar (two for 13) gave away seven in the penultimate one.

However, with eight runs required off the final

over, Axar's (2-0-7-0) experience came in handy as he didn't give any room to Shirai Patmore and Benjamin Ito-Davis to chance their arms.

Japan ended on 30 for three and a shock defeat could be averted. It also helped that rain had slowed down the outfield.

In the final over, umpire Chris Thurgate gave a few contentious wide ball calls when left-handed Patmore tried playing the reverse slog and missed twice.

An unhappy Shreyas complained to leg-umpire Chris Brown and the second wide was

overturned.

While Japan deserve credit, it was more about the rank turner that literally turned the match into a lottery.

Earlier, the unheralded Japanese spinners challenged the star-studded Indian batting line-up. Shreyas top-scored with a 12-ball 16 (1x4) as the favourite finished with a below-par total. But proved just enough.

The scores: India 32/4 in 5 overs (Shreyas 16, Hara-Hinze 2/17) bt Japan 30/3 in 5 overs (Kadowaki-Fleming 12, Washington 2/13). Toss: India; PoM: Shreyas.

Asnodkar named as Kerala coach

M.R. Praveen Chandran
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Former Goa First Class cricketer Swapnil Asnodkar has been named as the coach of the Kerala senior men's team for the 2026-27 domestic season. The Kerala Cricket Association, after considering Asnodkar's experience as coach of the Kerala under-23 cricket team, decided to appoint him as the coach of the senior team.

Devika Palshikar will continue as the coach of the senior women's cricket team. Former India cricketer Karuna Jain has been appointed as the coach of the Kerala under-19 women's team and also as the mentor of the KCA Women's Academy.

Former Ranji Trophy captain Rohan Prem has been appointed as the chairman of the senior selection committee. Former



Asnodkar.

Ranji skipper V.A. Jagadeesh and P.U. Anthaf are the other members of the selection panel.

Former Kerala all-rounder K. Chandrasekhara has been appointed as the chairman of the junior selection committee. K.R Sreejith and Ranji Philip are other members.

The women's selection committee, headed by E. Rency, with Rani Varghese and Anjana Paul as members, will continue for another season.

France coach Zidane swings into action

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Zinedine Zidane oversaw his first training session with the France national team on Monday as *Les Bleus* prepared for the start of the new Nations League campaign.

The 1998 World Cup winner led a dozen of players through a light training session at the country's national football centre, Clairefontaine. Michael Olise, Eduardo Camavinga, Jules Kounde and Dayot Upamecano featured in the 12-strong group but captain Kylian Mbappe, who played in Real Madrid's derby loss against Atletico Madrid on Sunday, was absent.

Zidane was joined for the session by assistant David Bettoni and Fabian Barthez, a former teammate from the 1998 World Cup and Euro 2000-winning



Zidane. AFP

sides and the current goal-keeping coach.

The session concluded with a short practice game, followed by shots on goal from crosses delivered by Zidane himself.

France has four Nations League fixtures after the first training camp of the Zidane era: away matches in Turkey and Belgium on September 25 and 28, followed by home matches against Italy and Belgium in early October.



Rescue act: Kushagra and Kotian applied themselves well. CAP

Kushagra, Kotian dig deep to revive India-A

Abhishek Saini
PUDUCHERRY

Kumar Kushagra (82 retired hurt, 160b, 10x4) and Tanush Kotian (68 batting, 134b, 4x4, 1x6) braved a rampant spin attack from Australia-A to salvage India-A's innings on the opening day of the first 'Test' at the Siechem Cricket Stadium here on Tuesday.

Their 138-run partnership was an ideal intervention after India-A had slumped to 97 for five, and it ended only because Kushagra retired hurt late in the day. Kotian did not let this disrupt his momentum, taking India-A to 257 for five at stumps.

Both were handed early reprieves. Kushagra was pinned by Brendan Doggett's in-seamer but a timely DRS saved him and revealed the ball to be going down leg. Kotian should have been snared behind off Todd Murphy had either Josh Philippe or the first slip held the chance.

Kushagra exercised restraint while setting up the recovery partnership and his only flourishing strokes, a drive off Corey Rocchiccioli (three for 72), and a flick and an on-drive off Doggett, came off over-pitched deliveries.

It was only when Kotian slog-swept Rocchiccioli off the first delivery of the third session and followed

it up with a cut through covers that India-A really put its foot down. Kushagra lapped up freebies angling down leg from Doggett and Liam Scott and glanced them through fine-leg for boundaries.

But the unwanted hurdle came from the sapping heat of Puducherry, which forced him to take a lengthy treatment for cramps in the 60th over. In the 79th over, he was forced to walk off.

In the first two sessions, Rocchiccioli and Murphy had tied the Indian batters around the off-stump line and used flight to generate extra bounce on the odd ball. It was how Murphy nabbed the in-form Devdutt Padikkal and got him to edge to first slip.

Rocchiccioli used a clever plan with a silly mid-on in place to force Shaik Rasheed into giving a return catch. B. Sai Sudharshan persevered for his 103-ball 57 but was left helpless after a long hop held up off the surface, took his leading edge and went back to Rocchiccioli.

Though Rocchiccioli took great catches on both occasions, he could not hold onto the momentum, which eventually shaped the day.

The scores: India-A 257/5 in 89 overs (B. Sai Sudharsan 57, Kumar Kushagra 82 rettd. hurt, Tanush Kotian 68 batting) vs. Australia-A; Toss: India-A.

Wood retires from international cricket

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

England fast bowler Mark Wood announced his retirement from international cricket on Tuesday, saying he had "lost the battle" after a career repeatedly disrupted by injuries.

The 36-year-old, one of the quickest bowlers to play for England, took 253 wickets in 146 international matches across all formats, including 119 wickets at 30.79 in his 38 Tests.

Wood, who made his England debut in 2015, played a key role in the team's 50-over World Cup triumph in 2019.



Wood FILE PHOTO

Delhi's Ranji home ties to be held at Palam

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

The Delhi & District Cricket Association (DDCA) has informed the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) that the Arun Jaitley Stadium would not be able to stage Delhi's home games in the first phase of the 2026-27 Ranji Trophy season.

The venue, which hosted three T20Is between India and Afghanistan last week, is set to undergo a renovation, with the DDCA looking to install a state-of-the-art drainage system.

Delhi has two home matches, against Gujarat (October 18-21) and Services (November 2-5), in the first four rounds of the Ranji Trophy.

These games will be held at the Air Force Sta-



Venue change: The Air Force Station Complex in Palam will host Delhi's home matches against Gujarat (Oct. 18-21) and Services (Nov. 2-5). FILE PHOTO: SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

tion Complex in Palam, which is the home base of Services. The First Class competition will pause in November for the white-ball events before resuming in January. Delhi has another home game against Maharashtra in the second phase, scheduled

from February 1 to 4.

The stadium, in the heart of the national capital, is also slated to host an ODI between India and Sri Lanka on December 13.

"The plan is to switch to a sand-based outfield. Our drainage system is lagging behind many grounds in

the country. As and when the work begins, it will take four to five months," said a DDCA official.

Delhi's opening fixture of the Ranji campaign is against Bengal at the Bengal Cricket Academy Ground in Kalyani from October 11 to 14.

F-1 commission nod for shorter races from 2027

Reuters
LONDON

The governing FIA's Formula One commission agreed on Monday to reduce the standard Grand Prix distance from 305km to 290km from 2027, cutting races by two or three laps.

The commission approved the change in line with planned refinements to 2027 power unit regulations concerning fuel flow.

They also agreed to remove the current three-hour maximum time limit from the start to finish of a race, including any interruptions caused by rain or other factors.

A two-hour limit on actual racing will remain.

TNPL was a new experience as the crowd was different: Vineeth

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

V.K. Vineeth didn't feature in Tamil Nadu's under-14 or under-16 teams.

But he made the Vinoo Mankad and Cooch Behar Trophy squads and, last season, emerged as the Vinoo Mankad Trophy's top run-scorer with 488 runs.

Then came the High Performance Camp at CoE, followed by a tour of Sri Lanka with India u-19, where he scored a hundred in a youth ODI.

Vineeth is part of India u-19's series against Australia. On Monday, he scored a gritty 87 as India sealed the series.

His story began in Chennai, where he started playing cricket at seven. His



Vineeth. SHAYAN ACHARYA

father, a Southern Railway RPF employee, introduced him to the game. His elder brother, K. Veeraviswa, who played Tamil Nadu u-19, became another influence.

The TNPL, however, gave him his first taste of a crowd. "When I went on to play the TNPL for the Dindigul Dragons this year, it was a whole new experience because the crowd was different. So playing in front of a crowd and under

the lights for the first time was unbelievable," Vineeth told *The Hindu*.

He initially carried water, but mentor R. Ashwin, B. Indrajith and Sandeep Warrier helped him settle. "They said whether the crowd comes or not, we are going to play cricket. That is our main part. The crowd is just an add-on."

Vineeth featured in three games for the Dindigul Dragons, scoring 82 runs.

A Virat Kohli fan, Vineeth has learnt to live with missed milestones. "I don't try to hide my mistakes. I try to understand what I have to improve and what I can take from the learnings," the 18-year-old said.

Match starts at 9 a.m.

The Women in Blue deserve to bask in their glory now. However, they need to work on their T20 game as tougher challenges await from stronger sides outside the continent



R.V. MOORTHY

 Young bowlers like Kranti and Nandani, *in pic.*, took on massive responsibilities

HARMANPREET
India captain

